

Race, redistribution, and partisanship: evidence from the COVID-19 pandemic

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Abstract

In the United States, support for means-tested transfers is associated with views about African Americans. After COVID-19, individuals may be more willing to support policies that assist those affected when risks are widely shared. We test this hypothesis in three survey experiments fielded between October 2020 and March 2021. Respondents primed to consider COVID-19's disproportionate burden on Black and Hispanic communities are less likely to support redistributive policies, primarily among Republican identifiers. Information about local pandemic severity has no measurable effect on support for public-health measures such as mask mandates and business closures. After the 2020 election, racial framing no longer moves Republican identifiers, though it continues to reduce support for explicitly redistributive taxes among non-Republicans.

Keywords: redistribution, racial attitudes, partisanship, survey experiment, COVID-19

1 Introduction

Support for redistributive public policies is shaped, in part, by their perceived beneficiaries. Diverse societies split along salient political cleavages tend to feature low levels of support for

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redistribution ([Alesina and Glaeser, 2004](#); [Dahlberg, Edmark, and Lundqvist, 2012](#); [Alesina and Stantcheva, 2020](#)). In the United States, support for means-tested transfer programs among White respondents is strongly associated with views about African Americans, and decreases with their negative evaluations of Black recipients ([Gilens, 1996](#)).

In the aftermath of unprecedented health and economic crises precipitated by the spread of COVID-19, however, individuals may be more willing to support public policies that assist those affected. A priori, we may expect that the public health challenge, which peaked at about 800,000 cases and more than 3,000 deaths per day, and the associated economic devastation, with employment among low-wage workers falling by 37% at the peak of the recession ([Chetty et al., 2020](#)), would buoy support for public policies that insure against adverse health and economic events.¹ In terms of how racial considerations may affect views about COVID policies in particular, [Efrid et al. \(2023\)](#) write “...resistance to pandemic-era public health mandates [...] has been deeply wrapped up in racial and right-wing ideologies and rhetoric regarding individualism” and “[...] being made aware of racial disparities in COVID-19 outcomes made White Americans less likely to support public health mandates[...]” Our setting allows us to investigate these claims over a period of several months when attitudes were changing. What is distinctive about our study is that we can isolate partisan affiliation as a mediating factor in the shaping of these attitudes.

To test these hypotheses, we conducted three survey experiments on a panel of respondents between October 2020 and March 2021.² We find that respondents are less likely to support redistributive policies when primed to consider that the burden of COVID-19 has fallen disproportionately on Black and Hispanic communities, a response driven primarily by those who identify as Republican. We also find that, in the weeks immediately after the 2020 election, informa-

¹Data on cases and deaths obtained from the New York Times COVID-19 database, accessed April 1, 2024.

²Protocol approved by Duke University IRB (Protocol 2021-0001). Wave 3 was registered in the AEA RCT Registry after fieldwork. The registered plan covers the design, agreement coding, imbalance-adjusted OLS, partisan interactions, and Benjamini–Hochberg false-discovery-rate adjustments. This manuscript also reports Waves 1 and 2, which were not pre-registered, and a narrower set of primary outcomes focused on redistributive tax items. We do not report the full set of heterogeneity tests listed in the plan.

tion about the severity of the pandemic had no measurable effect on respondents' support for public-health measures such as mask mandates, testing, and business closures. By March 2021, partisanship had come to structure these preferences: even a stronger treatment emphasizing racial disparities no longer influenced the views of Republican identifiers, although it continued to depress support for explicitly redistributive taxes outside that group. Taken together, these findings suggest that racial considerations can shape attitudes when partisan positions are still fluid. But once party lines are drawn, co-partisans align with their party's stance, leaving little room for persuasion, even from more forceful information cues. These patterns are robust in sign and significance to the choice of covariate adjustment, with details in the Online Appendix.

To rationalize this pattern, we develop a simple model of partisan cue-taking under uncertainty. Voters care about how close a policy is to their own ideal point and to where they think their party stands. The racial cue carries information about the party's historical stance on race-linked redistribution, and updates the voter's perceived party position toward that stance. The size of the update depends on how settled positions on the policy already are: when the party's position on a given proposal is still fluid, there is room for the cue to move beliefs and the cue depresses co-partisan support; when the party's position is common knowledge, the cue is informationally inert and has no effect on co-partisan support.

The asymmetry between the two parties' historical platforms makes this story primarily about Republican identifiers. The Republican party has a long-standing anti-redistribution stance on race-linked transfers, so the cue has a clear anchor to point to for Republican voters. The Democratic party's positions on redistributive and on race-linked policy are roughly aligned, so the cue does not carry comparable information about the Democratic position to Democratic voters. The model therefore predicts a Republican response to the cue when party positions on the policy are still fluid, and no response from either party when those positions have crystallized.

This logic maps onto the two waves of our experiment. In October 2020 the outgoing Republican administration is itself sponsoring generous COVID-19 relief, against the party's historical

grain, and Republican identifiers’ perception of where their party stands on the policy is uncertain. The cue moves their perceived party position toward the historical anti-redistribution stance, and the data show a sharp drop in Republican support for the most redistributive items under the racial framing. By March 2021, with a Democratic administration in office and Republican opposition to the Biden program established as partisan common knowledge, the cue has no further room to move Republican beliefs about the party’s position. The same racial frame, in fact a stronger one, no longer moves Republican support in net, as the model predicts; a complementary possibility is a floor effect, since Republican control-group agreement on the wealth and income taxes had already fallen sharply between waves, leaving less room for the cue to push support down further. The Wave-3 data also show, however, that the cue continues to depress support for the wealth tax and higher income taxes among non-Republicans, and that this effect is concentrated on the most explicitly redistributive items rather than on universal ones. The model in Section 1.1 does not predict this pattern, and a floor effect cannot account for it either: non-Republican control-group agreement on those tax items remains high, so there is still room for preferences to fall. We present the non-Republican response as evidence that racial framing operates through additional channels beyond the partisan cue-taking we formalize here, and discuss its empirical content in Section 4.

1.1 A model of partisan cue-taking under uncertainty

Consider a uni-dimensional policy space $[0, 1] \subset \mathbb{R}$ representing redistributive policy, where lower values denote more generous redistribution. Voters have exogenous partisan identities P_j and policy ideal points $x_j \in [0, 1]$ drawn independently of partisan identity. The utility of voter j from policy p in the presence of racial cue $\rho \in \{0, 1\}$ is

$$U_j(p, \rho) = -(1 - \alpha)(x_j - p)^2 - \alpha (\bar{x}_{P_j}(\rho) - p)^2, \quad (1)$$

where $\bar{x}_{P_j}(\rho) \in [0, 1]$ is the voter's perceived position of their party on the policy, and $\alpha \in [0, 1]$ is the weight the voter places on partisan alignment relative to their own ideal point. When $\alpha = 0$, the voter ignores partisan considerations and supports the policy closest to x_j ; when $\alpha = 1$, only the perceived gap to the party's position matters. Voters with no party affiliation have $\alpha = 0$.

The racial cue moves the voter's perceived party position. Without the cue, $\bar{x}_{P_j}(0)$ is the voter's baseline perception, denoted $\bar{x}_{P_j}^N$. With the cue, the perception shifts toward an anchor $\bar{x}_{P_j}^T$ that captures the party's historical stance on race-linked redistribution:

$$\bar{x}_{P_j}(1) = \bar{x}_{P_j}^N + \theta_t (\bar{x}_{P_j}^T - \bar{x}_{P_j}^N), \quad (2)$$

where $\theta_t \in [0, 1]$ is a period- and group-specific parameter capturing how much room the cue has to update perceived party position. When $\theta_t = 0$, the voter is already certain about where their party stands on the policy and the cue has no purchase. When $\theta_t = 1$, the cue replaces the baseline perception with the race-targeted anchor. Intermediate values represent partial updates.

We make two substantive assumptions about the parties:

- (A1) Republican party: $\bar{x}_R^N \geq p$ and $\bar{x}_R^T > \bar{x}_R^N$. Republican identifiers' baseline perception of where their party stands is at least as far right as the proposed generous policy, and the race-targeted anchor is further right still, reflecting the party's historical opposition to race-linked transfers.
- (A2) Democratic party: $\bar{x}_D^T \approx \bar{x}_D^N$. The Democratic party's positions on redistributive and race-linked policy are roughly aligned, so the cue does not carry comparable information about the Democratic position to Democratic identifiers.

The cue's effect on voter j 's utility from supporting policy p is

$$\Delta U_j^{(t)} \equiv U_j(p, 1) - U_j(p, 0) = -\alpha \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{P_j} \left[2(\bar{x}_{P_j}^N - p) + \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{P_j} \right], \quad (3)$$

where $\Delta\bar{x}_{P_j} \equiv \bar{x}_{P_j}^T - \bar{x}_{P_j}^N$ is the partisan position gap. The derivation is in the Online Appendix.

For Republican identifiers under (A1), $\Delta\bar{x}_R > 0$ and $\bar{x}_R^N - p \geq 0$, so $\Delta U_j^{(t)} \leq 0$ whenever $\theta_t > 0$ and $\alpha > 0$. The cue weakly reduces Republican support, with a magnitude that is increasing in the weight on partisan alignment α , in the partisan position gap $\Delta\bar{x}_R$, and in the room available for the cue to move beliefs θ_t . For Democratic identifiers under (A2), $\Delta\bar{x}_D \approx 0$ implies $\Delta U_j^{(t)} \approx 0$ regardless of θ_t .

We consider two periods corresponding to the transition from a Republican to a Democratic administration during the COVID-19 pandemic in late 2020. In both periods, the same redistributive policy p is under consideration, with lower p denoting more generous redistribution. We index period-specific quantities by the survey wave in which each period is measured, so period-1 quantities carry the subscript 1 (Wave 1, October 2020) and period-2 quantities carry the subscript 3 (Wave 3, March 2021); Wave 2, which contains no racial treatment, plays no role in the model.

Period 1: Republican incumbent. COVID-19 relief in October 2020 is a new issue. The outgoing Republican administration is itself sponsoring generous transfers, against the party’s historical grain, so Republican identifiers’ baseline perception of where their party stands on the policy is uncertain. In the notation of the model, θ_1^R is large and the cue carries substantial information for Republicans: it points to the party’s traditional anti-transfer stance on race-linked redistribution. The model predicts a sharp drop in Republican support for the policy under the racial framing. Democratic identifiers’ positions on redistributive and race-linked policy are aligned, with $\Delta\bar{x}_D \approx 0$, so the cue produces no detectable effect on their support, regardless of θ_1^D .

Period 2: Democratic incumbent. By March 2021, the partisan landscape has crystallized. Republican opposition to the Biden-era COVID-19 program is established as partisan common knowledge, so $\theta_3^R \rightarrow 0$ and the cue is informationally inert for Republicans regardless of the size of $\Delta\bar{x}_R$. The same racial framing, in fact a stronger one, no longer moves Republican support. For

Democratic identifiers, the model continues to predict $\Delta U_j^{(t)} \approx 0$ via $\Delta \bar{x}_D \approx 0$.

The model formalizes partisan cue-taking under uncertainty about party positions on a new policy. It explains the Wave-1 Republican response to the racial cue and the Wave-3 Republican null. The Wave-3 finding that the cue continues to depress support for the wealth tax and higher income taxes among non-Republicans is not predicted by the model. We discuss it empirically in Section 4 and treat it as evidence that racial framing operates through additional channels we do not formalize here.

1.2 Related literature

Regarding preferences, political economists have theorized three sets of determinants: material incentives, in-group out-group differences, and major crises, such as international wars, economic depressions or pandemics. Material incentives posit a link between income and wealth and support for redistribution (Meltzer and Richard, 1981). The central contention in this family of arguments is that, to the extent that income drives preferences, economic inequality fuels polarization across income ranks regarding redistribution. This would be the case at any given point in time and when factoring future income expectations (Rueda and Stegmueller, 2019).

Much like economic inequality, in-group out-group differences, whether by race, religion or nation, work to undermine the feasibility of pro-redistributive coalitions. Dominant groups' efforts to preserve relative group position, and the backlash triggered when that position is threatened, make broad-based mobilization for redistribution more difficult (Blumer, 1958; Darity, 2005). The literature has identified several channels through which the coexistence of multiple races, ethnicities, national identities, religions or other politically salient groups undermines redistribution. Heterogeneity renders the necessary coordination for the provision of public goods less likely (Poterba, 1997). In-group members refuse to potentially share their assets with out-group members through pooled solutions. As a result, collective initiatives are both less likely and less sustainable (Habyarimana et al., 2009). Heterogeneity undermines the emergence of

“communities of fate” ([Ahlquist and Levi, 2013](#)), conditions perceptions of deservingness and, by implication, fairness and support for redistribution across groups ([Cavaillé, 2023](#)) and tends to exacerbate inter-group conflicts over scarce resources ([Alesina and Glaeser, 2004](#); [Alesina and Giuliano, 2011](#)) and fuel partisan backlash ([Cavaillé and Ferwerda, 2023](#)). Conversely, collective action efforts towards public goods provision and the expansion of comprehensive forms of public insurance tend to be significantly more ambitious in ethnically homogeneous polities.

The final set of factors shaping preferences, namely the role of major crises, works in the opposite direction. A widely shared understanding among political economists is that major crises that generate a need for risk sharing facilitate an increase in support for redistribution, either across people or territories. Recent work suggests, for instance, that high income citizens favor redistributive interventions if they are more likely to experience negative externalities from inequality, such as crime ([Rueda and Stegmueller, 2019](#)). There is also evidence that in the context of economic crises, rich regions are willing to transfer resources to poor regions in federations if they are more likely to experience negative externalities in the form of migration ([Beramendi, 2012](#)). Historically, welfare state expansions tend to reflect overlapping distributions of income and risk: coverage grows when those with the capacity to contribute perceive themselves to be vulnerable to negative outcomes ([Rehm, 2016](#)). Major crises tend to increase the overlap between the distributions of income and risk, potentially offsetting the polarizing effect of economic inequality and/or inter-group heterogeneity. Under these conditions, short term income losses would be dominated by the benefits of greater insurance. Its importance notwithstanding, risk sharing is far from the only relevant dimension in the political economy of crises.³

Taken together, these three factors shape the distribution of voters’ ideal points on redistribution. While each individual factor is reasonably well understood, there are very few analytical opportunities to examine systematically how they combine in shaping voter’s preferences as well

³For instance, depending on the nature of the incumbent’s response, major shocks can also lead to growing distrust of institutions and political disengagement, paving the way for populist reactions ([Margalit, 2019](#)).

as the evolution of such preferences in a politically polarized environment. It is indeed rare to find settings in which the forces driving preferences are clearly at odds: risk sharing against a common shock on one side, and opposition to policies perceived to benefit disfavored groups on the other. The United States is, among rich countries, the one in which racial diversity has had the strongest grip on the development of social policy institutions ([Lieberman, 1998](#)). Hence, analyzing the political consequences of COVID-19 in the United States provides an ideal case study for assessing the relative importance of risk sharing and diversity in shaping political responses to crises. Experimental work on the pandemic sharpens this tension. [Stephens-Dougan \(2023\)](#) randomly assigned a nationally representative sample of White Americans to information about racial disparities in COVID-19 deaths and found that the cue moved racially prejudiced Whites toward resistance to public-health precautions. Treated respondents in that study placed less importance on mask-wearing, were more likely to view shelter-in-place orders as threats to individual rights, and expressed greater skepticism that African Americans follow social-distancing guidelines, while Whites who did not endorse anti-Black stereotypes responded more sympathetically. Our Wave 1 design explores this logic further by considering redistributive COVID relief and contrasts a racial frame with a poverty frame fielded on the same respondents.

In the United States, opposition to welfare policies can be rationalized by positing that respondents over-estimate the proportion of welfare recipients who are from a particular group, such as African Americans, whom they consider undeserving because they hold unfavorable views about group members' work ethic ([Gilens, 1996](#); [Alesina and Stantcheva, 2020](#)). Opposition may also reflect general animus toward out-groups as a threat to a dominant group's privileged status, not only stereotypes about work ethic ([Blumer, 1958](#); [Darity, 2005](#)). Still some work finds that opposition to welfare stems from a fear that recipients may become dependent ([Cooley, Brown-Iannuzzi, and Boudreau, 2019](#)). Such fears of dependency may likewise function as a convenient rationalization for opposing transfers that respondents would reject on group-position grounds in any event. Taken together, these factors explain unfavorable attitudes towards race-neutral

programs stemming from respondents' views about the racial composition of beneficiaries, their laziness, and the risk of encouraging welfare dependency. While these considerations may apply to standard policy questions, extant research on risk-pooling events suggests these predispositions should be muted in the aftermath of a large negative shock like the COVID-19 pandemic, when work ethic and dependency are much less relevant.

In the rest of the paper, we describe an experimental design to examine two questions posited by the joint consideration of (1) determinants of preference formation and (2) changes in context driven by the resolution of partisan position-uncertainty on emerging policies, that is changes in θ_t of Eq. (2):

1. How do inter-group heterogeneity and a major event homogenizing risks across the whole population combine in shaping preferences for redistribution in multi-racial societies? Here we distinguish two possibilities:
 - (a) Dominance of inter-group resentment (H1)
 - (b) Dominance of risk-pooling effect associated with the pandemic (H2)
2. How does the process of preference formation interact with partisanship in a highly polarized environment? When party positions on an emerging policy are still uncertain, racial cues carry information about the party's stance, and co-partisans update their support for redistribution toward the party's historical position on the racialized version of the policy (H3). Once the party's position on the policy is established as common knowledge, the cue is informationally inert for co-partisans and party positions alone determine their preferences (H4).

2 Empirical design

We test whether support for a number of public policies is affected by messages that are randomly assigned to respondents. In wave 1, one of the treatment arms informs respondents of the disproportionate impact of COVID-19 on Black and Hispanic communities, and another informs them on the disproportionate effect on poor communities. Randomized allocation to treatment groups allows us to credibly assign differences in responses to the messages viewed by participants. The order in which respondents viewed the policy proposals also was randomized to ensure that the results obtained in this study were not order-dependent. In wave 2, the treatment involves informing respondents about the actual number of cases and deaths in their state of residence. In wave 3, one of the treatment arms provides state level data showing a disproportionate impact of COVID-19 on African Americans relative to Whites, while another provides data showing the opposite.

Treatment and control groups are relatively well balanced across most covariates of interest, but we also report the results from specifications in which we include additional controls. Instead of T-tests of mean differences across groups, we instead examine the standardized maximum mean difference. Characteristics with a difference greater than 0.1 of a standard deviation are considered imbalanced ([Stuart, Lee, and Leacy, 2013](#), S85). Appendix Figure [A1](#) plots the standardized maximum mean difference across groups for variables of interest for Waves 1, 2, and 3. The estimation framework is as follows:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta T_i + W_i' \Theta + \epsilon_i, \quad (4)$$

where T_i is an indicator variable for whether respondents were assigned to the treatment group and W_i is a vector of control variables. In our canonical specification, W_i comprises a fixed adjustment set for each wave: employment, family income, and race indicators, together with ideology in Wave 1 and education in Wave 3. This set covers the covariates that exceed the 0.1

standardized-difference threshold plus standard demographic controls. Party identification is excluded from the canonical Wave 3 specification because it is the moderator in our interaction models; alternative specifications that add it, along with richer control sets, are reported in the Online Appendix.

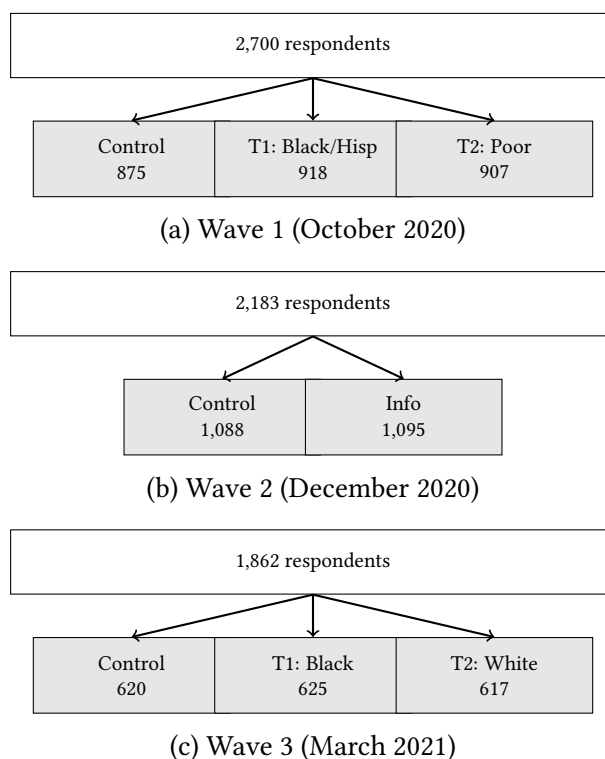


Figure 1: Assignment of respondents to study arms in Waves 1–3.

Note: Cell counts are the number of respondents randomized to each arm.

3 Data

Data was collected through an original survey of 2,700 respondents in six states between October 19 and October 23, 2020. Online Appendix Figure [OA.1](#) locates the three survey waves relative to major COVID relief legislation, the 2020 election, and the presidential inauguration. Respondents were part of a survey panel maintained by the public opinion survey firm YouGov. An initial

sample of 3,077 respondents were interviewed. Respondents were matched to a sampling frame on gender, age, race, and education to generate samples that were representative at the level of each state: Illinois, Kentucky, Missouri, North Carolina, Tennessee, and Virginia. These states were chosen to vary in partisan composition and in Medicaid expansion status, while remaining in relatively close geographic proximity. Each state yielded 450 respondents. Figure 1 shows randomized assignment of respondents to treatment arms in Waves 1–3.

The survey included questions about political background and economic conditions, as well as specific questions related to exposure to COVID-19, changes in employment status, application for and receipt of government assistance, as well as views on public policies. The complete list of survey questions is included in the replication supplement. Basic demographic information, including age, gender, race, education, family income, political ideology, and party identification was available for all respondents at the outset.

Before the policy questions in Table 1, respondents also viewed one of three messages that differed in a single sentence. The sample was assigned randomly to the three messages. The control group saw the following message:

Since March 2020, more than 7 million Americans have contracted COVID-19, of whom more than 200,000 have died. The government agency responsible for public health - the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) - reports that ***the impact of COVID-19 differs across communities, cities and states*** (emphasis added).

Remaining respondents composed two treatment groups. In the first, which we will refer to as the *Black and Hispanic* treatment, respondents were presented with the following message:

Since March 2020, more than 7 million Americans have contracted COVID-19, of whom more than 200,000 have died. The government agency responsible for public health - the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) - reports that

Table 1: List of policy questions

Policy	Question text
Univ health insurance	I support extending health insurance to all Americans, regardless of employment status for a small monthly premium payable by those covered by the program.
Free univ health ins	I support extending health insurance to all Americans, regardless of employment status, and at no cost to those being covered. The costs would be met through tax revenues.
Federal job guarantee	I support offering employment to all job seekers who are unable to find a job through a federal job guarantee program.
Longer unemp benefits	I support extending unemployment benefits for as long as it takes for the economy to return to its employment level before the COVID-19 pandemic.
+\$600 unemp benefits	I support expanding weekly unemployment benefits by up to \$600 (\$2,400 a month) through the end of 2020.
Wealth tax	I support the introduction of a wealth tax on households with more than \$25 million in wealth holdings in order to raise revenues to reduce the deficit and fund programs that were introduced in response to COVID-19.
Higher income tax	I support an increase in income taxes for households earning above \$200,000

COVID-19 disproportionately affects black and hispanic communities, where cases and deaths are higher than in the rest of the population (emphasis added).

In the second, which we will refer to as the *poverty* treatment, respondents were presented with the following message:

Since March 2020, more than 7 million Americans have contracted COVID-19, of whom more than 200,000 have died. The government agency responsible for public health - the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) - reports that ***COVID-19 disproportionately affects poor communities, where cases and deaths are higher than in the rest of the population*** (emphasis added).

The survey questions following these messages elicited respondents' agreement or disagreement with the policy proposals listed in Table 1, among others. The full list of survey questions is in the replication supplement.

Respondents indicated whether they strongly agreed, somewhat agreed, neither agreed nor disagreed, somewhat disagreed, or strongly disagreed with each of these statements. To analyze

the impact of treatment on respondents' views, we group the two options "strongly agree" and "somewhat agree" into a single category, and group the rest into its complement. Henceforth, when referring to *agreement* with a policy proposal, we mean respondents either choosing that they strongly or somewhat agree. There was significant variation in baseline rates of agreement across the six policy proposals in the control group; responses from those in the control group are shown in Online Appendix Figures [OA.2](#) and [OA.3](#). A federal job guarantee drew the highest support (75.7%), followed by the wealth tax (66.9%) and universal health insurance (65.7%); free universal health insurance drew the lowest (56.6%), with the \$600 weekly unemployment top-up (62.4%) and higher income taxes (60.8%) in between. This, however, masks a large partisan gap: control-group agreement is far higher among Democratic than Republican identifiers on every item.

A second wave was deployed in December 2020, in which respondents were randomly assigned into an informational treatment group or the control group; Figure [1b](#) shows the assignment. Those in the informational treatment group received accurate information about the number of cases and deaths in their state, while those in the control group did not.

A final wave was deployed in March 2021; Figure [1c](#) shows the design. In this survey experiment, respondents received one of two treatment messages. In the first, they saw state-level information on cases and deaths, in which African Americans experienced a disproportionate burden, relative to Whites. In the second, they saw information that conveyed the opposite message. Finally, in the control group, respondents saw a neutral message that showed the overall number of cases and deaths without breaking down the totals by race. The figures shown in each treatment arm were drawn from four states chosen to display the relevant disparity and the reported case and death rates were accurate at the time of the survey.

4 Results

Appendix Table A1 reports our main estimates. Each panel uses the canonical specification in Equation 4: the full sample, race indicators with White omitted, and the canonical adjustment set for that wave. Treatment arms are balanced on most covariates; the adjustment set combines the imbalance-flagged covariates with standard demographic controls, and the standardized differences are shown in Appendix Figures A1a and A1c. Full-coefficient versions of these regressions appear in Appendix Tables A2 and A3. Main-effect rows compare each treatment arm to control; Treatment $\times$ Republican rows give the additional effect among Republican identifiers; total-effect rows report the implied treatment effect among non-Republicans and among Republicans from the interaction model.⁴ Figures 2a–2b and 4a–4b plot the Wave 1 and Wave 3 treatment estimates discussed below.

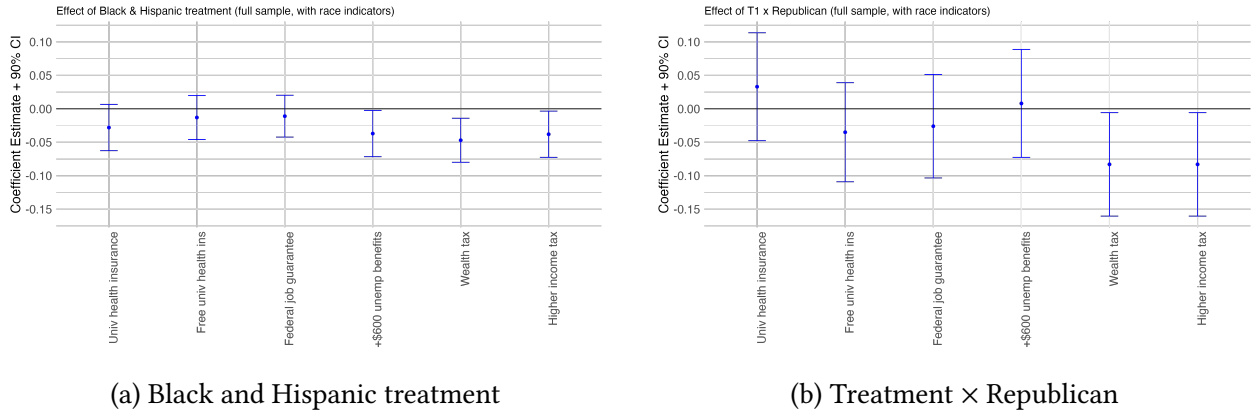


Figure 2: Wave 1 Black-and-Hispanic treatment effects and Republican interactions.

Note: coefficients and 90% confidence intervals; canonical specification per Equation 4.

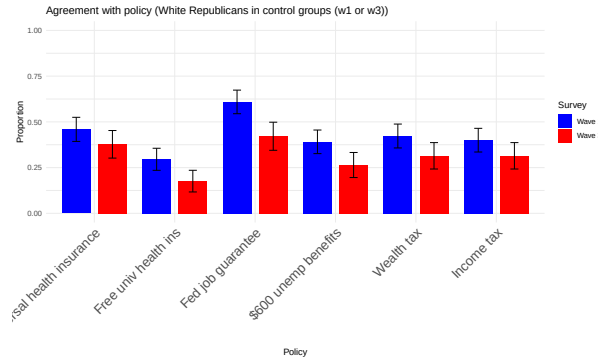
Wave 1 (October 2020). The Minorities arm reduces agreement on every policy in Appendix Table A1, with statistically significant declines on the \$600 weekly unemployment top-up (-0.037 , $p < 0.10$), the wealth tax (-0.047 , $p < 0.05$), and higher income taxes (-0.038 , $p < 0.10$). Coeffi-

⁴Throughout, a Republican (Democratic) identifier is a respondent whose three-category party identification is Republican (Democratic); party leaners are grouped with Independents and are therefore counted as non-Republican.

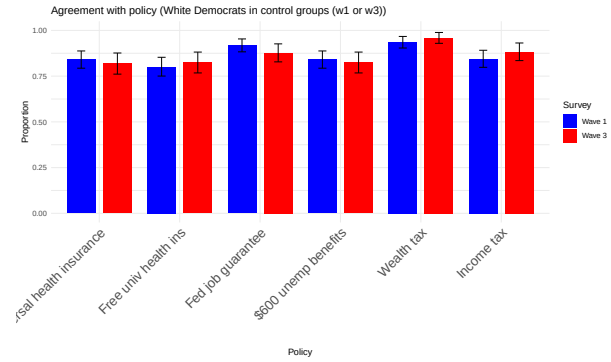
cients on the two health-insurance items and the federal job guarantee are negative but imprecise. The Treatment $\times$ Republican rows show that the tax effects are concentrated among Republican identifiers: the interaction is roughly -0.083 on both the wealth tax and higher income taxes, each with $p < 0.10$, as shown in Figure 2b. The \$600 unemployment top-up does not follow that partisan pattern: its Treatment $\times$ Republican coefficient is near zero and statistically indistinguishable from zero. The poverty-focused arm behaves differently. Its only statistically significant main effect is a decline in support for universal health insurance (-0.041 , $p < 0.10$). Among Republicans, the poverty cue's interaction with Republican identification on free universal health insurance is -0.118 ($p < 0.01$), so that the implied total effect among Republican identifiers is a decline of about 9 percentage points (-0.092 , $p < 0.05$), with no comparable decline on the tax items. Prior to the 2020 election, racialized frames reduced support for the most explicitly redistributive policies. On the tax items that decline was concentrated among Republican identifiers; among non-Republicans those tax effects are not detectable. The \$600 unemployment top-up declined in the aggregate without a detectable Republican interaction. That the racial frame depressed rather than raised support is consistent with the dominance of inter-group resentment over the risk-pooling channel in Wave 1 (H1 over H2), and its concentration among Republican identifiers is consistent with partisan cue-taking while party positions on COVID relief were still unsettled (H3).

Wave 2 (December 2020). Providing accurate state-level information on cases and deaths did not measurably alter attitudes toward the public-health measures in the Wave 2 battery, such as mask mandates, testing, and business closures (see Online Appendix Table OA.4 and Online Appendix Figure OA.8). We read this null as evidence that factual information alone did little to shift preferences.

Partisan realignment between Waves 1 and 3. Between October 2020 and March 2021, control-group baselines shifted in ways consistent with party positions hardening after the elec-



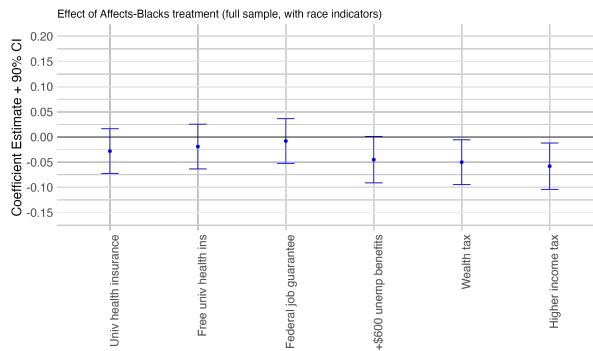
(a) White Republicans



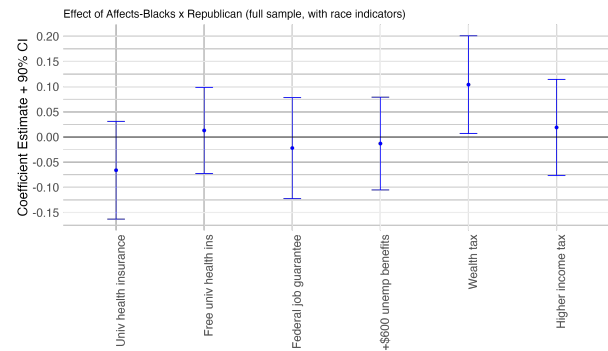
(b) White Democrats

Figure 3: Control-group agreement in Waves 1 and 3, by party.

tion. Among White Republican identifiers, agreement fell on every policy from Wave 1 to Wave 3; among White Democrats, baselines were stable. Figures 3a and 3b show these patterns. By March 2021, a Democratic administration had tied redistributive COVID relief to the out-party brand, restoring the partisan gradient that had been muted while a Republican incumbent enacted programs that included generous transfers.



(a) Affects-Blacks treatment



(b) Affects-Blacks $\times$ Republican

Figure 4: Wave 3 Affects-Blacks treatment effects and Republican interactions.

Note: coefficients and 90% confidence intervals; canonical Wave 3 specification per Equation 4.

Wave 3 (March 2021). The "affects-Blacks" arm again reduces support for the wealth tax (-0.050 , $p < 0.10$) and higher income taxes (-0.058 , $p < 0.05$), as shown in Figure 4a. The "affects-Whites" arm produces no statistically significant pooled main effects, and its interactions

with Republican identification are likewise null in Appendix Table A1; the only significant estimate for this arm is a positive total effect on the federal job guarantee among non-Republicans (+0.064, $p < 0.05$). The Treatment $\times$ Republican interaction reverses the Wave 1 pattern on the wealth tax: the coefficient is positive (+0.104, $p < 0.10$; Figure 4b), offsetting the aggregate decline within the Republican subgroup. Republican identifiers no longer respond to the racial cue once party positions on the Biden-era program had crystallized, the pattern anticipated by H4: with the party’s stance established as common knowledge, the cue is informationally inert for co-partisans. Outside that subgroup, the Affects-Blacks frame continues to depress support for the wealth and income taxes but not universal items such as health insurance or the federal job guarantee. This within-wave heterogeneity across questions for non-Republicans is not predicted by the partisan cue-taking model. We treat it as evidence that racial framing also operates through beliefs about who benefits from explicitly redistributive instruments.

The sign and statistical significance of the patterns reported in this section are stable across the choice of covariate adjustment; their magnitudes are more sensitive. The Online Appendix plots each treatment coefficient across nested specifications ranging from no controls through the canonical adjustment set used in the main text to richer specifications that further add partisanship, ideology, and for Wave 3 only, the respondent’s own Wave-1 response to the same policy item as a baseline control. The Wave 1 negative main effects on the wealth tax, income tax, and the \$600 unemployment top-up under the Black-and-Hispanic cue, the Wave 3 negative main effects on the wealth and income taxes under the “affects-Blacks” cue, the negative Wave 1 Minorities $\times$ Rep interactions on the two tax outcomes, and the positive Wave 3 “affects-Blacks” $\times$ Rep interaction on the wealth tax all keep their sign and significance in every specification. Their magnitudes attenuate as controls are added. In Wave 1, moving from no controls to the canonical specification, which adds ideology, shrinks the Black-and-Hispanic main effects by roughly a third: the wealth-tax coefficient moves from -0.068 to -0.047 , higher income taxes from -0.062 to -0.038 , and the \$600 top-up from -0.056 to -0.037 . In Wave 3, the richer spec-

ifications add party identification, ideology, and the respondent’s own Wave-1 response to the same item. Adding party identification and ideology attenuates the “affects-Blacks” wealth-tax coefficient from -0.050 ($p = 0.068$) to -0.040 ($p = 0.086$); the Wave-1 baseline leaves the point estimate unchanged but tightens the confidence interval, so the estimate is conventionally significant ($p = 0.038$) only in the fullest specification. The raw treatment-control differences in mean agreement, computed without any covariate adjustment and broken out by race and by party identification, reproduce these patterns from the data in Figure 5.

Following the Wave 3 registered analysis plan, we also apply Benjamini-Hochberg false discovery rate adjustments alongside the conventional tests above. We report two families. Family A comprises the twenty-four Wave 3 coefficients that appear in the main summary table as pooled main effects and Treatment $\times$ Republican interactions for both treatment arms across the six policy outcomes. Family B is the six-test primary redistributive battery in the plan: main effects of the affects-Blacks and affects-Whites arms on the \$600 unemployment top-up, the wealth tax, and higher income taxes. Under either family, no coefficient remains significant once the false-discovery rate is controlled at 0.10. The Wave 3 patterns we emphasize are therefore suggestive on conventional criteria and do not survive the plan’s multiple-testing correction.

5 Conclusion

This paper investigates the role of partisan salience in mediating the well-documented relationship between preferences for redistribution and beliefs about its likely beneficiaries. A long standing literature mainly focused on the United States has established that White respondents express lower support for redistributive policies when they expect that African Americans will benefit from the transfers made. With this in mind, emphasizing that minority communities were disproportionately affected by the COVID-19 pandemic would make policies aimed at addressing the harm more likely to be perceived as benefiting those communities. We would expect, therefore,

that support for such policies declines among respondents in the relevant treatment group. What we find instead is that the effect of racialized frames has a partisan dimension. In the waning days of a Republican presidency in late 2020, baseline support among Republican identifiers for a variety of redistributive policies is relatively high, including a surprising majority who support a federal job guarantee (see Online Appendix Figure [OA.3](#)). Among this group, the racial frame emphasizing the impact of COVID-19 on minority communities reduces support for a wealth tax and an increase in income taxes; among non-Republicans those tax effects are not detectable.

Following the presidential election of 2020, and the change from a Republican administration to a Democratic one, baseline support for all the policies we investigate declines among Republican identifiers, but there is no analogous increase in support among Democratic identifiers in the sample. We then expose the entire sample to an informational experiment with stronger racial priming, in which one treatment arm sees state-level data on the disproportionate incidence of COVID-19 among Black residents and another sees data emphasizing the burden on White residents. Unlike the pre-election experiment, the stronger racial frame no longer shifted Republican identifiers' views on the redistributive policies. On the wealth tax, the partisan interaction essentially offsets the aggregate decline. Outside of Republican identifiers, however, the "affects-Blacks" cue continued to depress support for the wealth tax and higher income taxes.

How can we explain these seemingly contradictory results? A relatively gentle racial frame in October 2020 reduced Republican support for redistributive policies, yet a stronger frame in March 2021 had no detectable net effect among that same group. The distinction between average and marginal effects is important here. Republican identifiers maintained comparatively lower support for redistributive policies throughout, but by March 2021 the racial-disparities cue no longer produced a significant further increase in their opposition. We argue that support for redistributive COVID programs had already declined among Republican identifiers because the party in power had changed. Control-group approval of the wealth tax among Republican identifiers fell by more than 10 percentage points between Wave 1 and Wave 3, similar in magnitude

to the Wave 1 treatment-induced decline. That baseline decline also opens a floor-effect reading of the Republican null: once agreement is already low, the cue has less room to reduce it further. Alternatively, once party positions had crystallized, Republican identifiers no longer needed an external racial cue to arrive at the position associated with their party.

The racial frame did not change meaning between the two waves, and we have no reason to think voters' underlying racial attitudes changed either. What changed is which voters the frame could still move, and why. In October 2020, the frame reduced support among Republican identifiers; among non-Republicans the tax effects were not detectable. At that point, party positions on COVID relief were still unsettled, and the frame appeared to push Republicans toward the party's traditional anti-redistribution stance. By March 2021, party positions had hardened. The frame no longer moved Republicans on any policy. Among non-Republicans, however, it reduced support for the wealth tax and higher income taxes, policies where the beneficiaries are most clearly redistributive. Race therefore continues to shape policy preferences throughout the study. The open question is not whether race matters, but when it works through partisanship and when it works through beliefs about who benefits.

Viewed together, race-based framing continues to shift redistributive preferences throughout the study period but never for the same group twice. The model of partisan cue-taking under uncertainty in Section 1.1 accounts for the Republican response in Wave 1, when party positions on the new COVID-19 program are uncertain (H3), and for the Republican null in Wave 3, when party positions are common knowledge (H4); the Wave 1 depression of support, rather than the risk-pooling boost, also indicates that inter-group resentment dominated in that wave (H1 over H2). A floor effect is a complementary reading of that Republican null: control-group agreement on the wealth and income taxes among Republican identifiers had already fallen sharply between waves, leaving less room for further downward movement. Neither the model nor a floor effect accounts for the Wave 3 non-Republican response on the wealth and income taxes. Non-Republican control-group agreement on those items remains high. We read that finding as

evidence that race continues to shape redistributive preferences through additional channels we do not formalize.

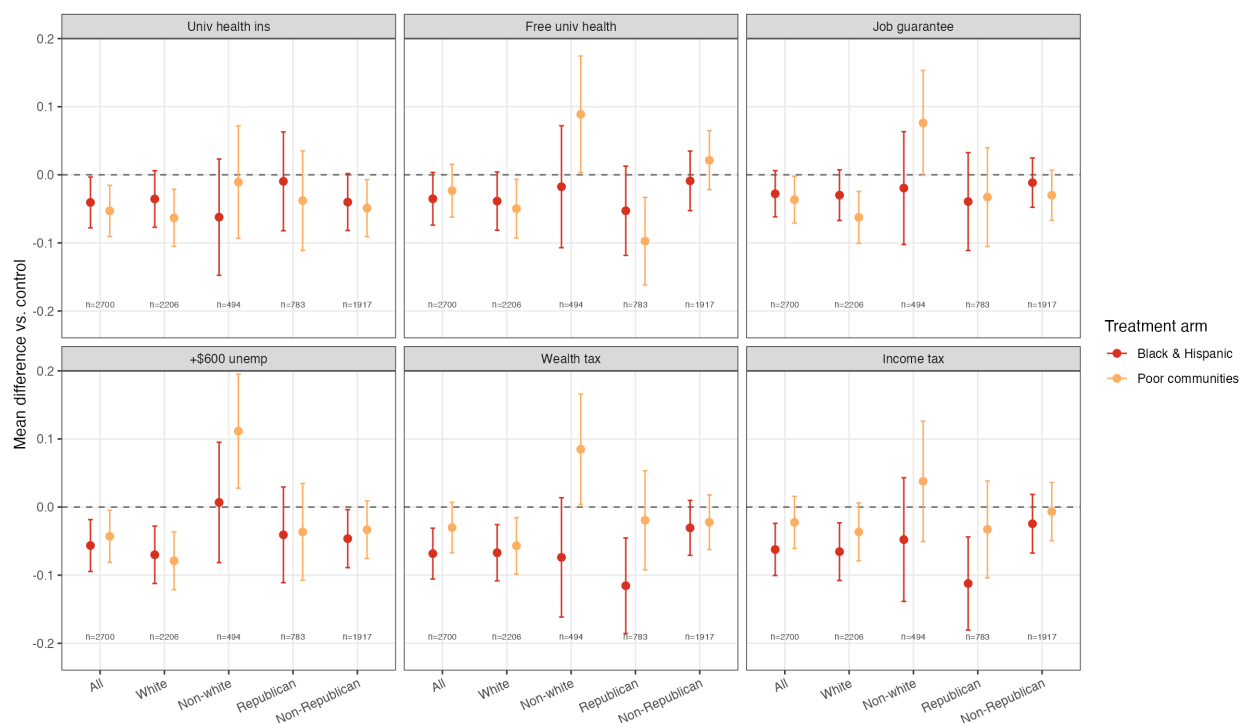


Figure 5: Wave 1 raw treatment-control differences in mean agreement, by subgroup.

Note: points are the mean agreement in each treatment arm minus the mean agreement in the control arm, without covariate adjustment. Bars are 90% confidence intervals based on heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. Panels correspond to the six policy questions; columns partition respondents into all, White, non-White, Republican, and non-Republican.

While racial framing appears to reduce support for redistributive policies, a descriptive heterogeneity analysis suggests that economic framing may actually elicit more support for the public policies we study than racial framing even among non-Whites (see Figure 5). The figure plots raw treatment-control differences in mean agreement without any covariate controls and broken out by race and party. Among non-White respondents, the poverty frame tends to increase support relative to control across the six policy items, whereas the Black-and-Hispanic frame is closer to zero or negative on the same outcomes. In several panels the gap between the two frames is visible: class-based framing appears more effective at raising agreement among non-Whites than racial framing. Among White respondents, the pattern runs in the opposite direction.

Both frames reduce support relative to control on several items, but the Black-and-Hispanic cue generally depresses agreement by at least as much as, and often more than the poverty cue. We treat these results as suggestive since they compare unadjusted means and are not powered for formal subgroup inference. Taken together, however, they sketch a dichotomy in which racialized beneficiary cues depress support among Whites while class-based cues are comparatively more mobilizing among non-Whites. Framing public policies in terms of economic need rather than racial disparity may therefore build broader coalitions across racial groups.

Finally, we caution against reading our findings as implying that the nexus between race, partisanship, and resistance to public health mandates is the fundamental reason the United States lacks universal government provision of public health services. A major barrier is resistance from private industry, especially the medical industry ([Levitt and Singh, 2025](#); [Gruessner, 2023](#); [Kreidler, 2019](#)). At the same time, a majority of Americans say the federal government has a responsibility to ensure health care coverage for all, including 35% who favor a single-payer system. This suggests that majority preferences need not translate directly into policy outcomes ([Daniller, 2025](#)).

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Appendix

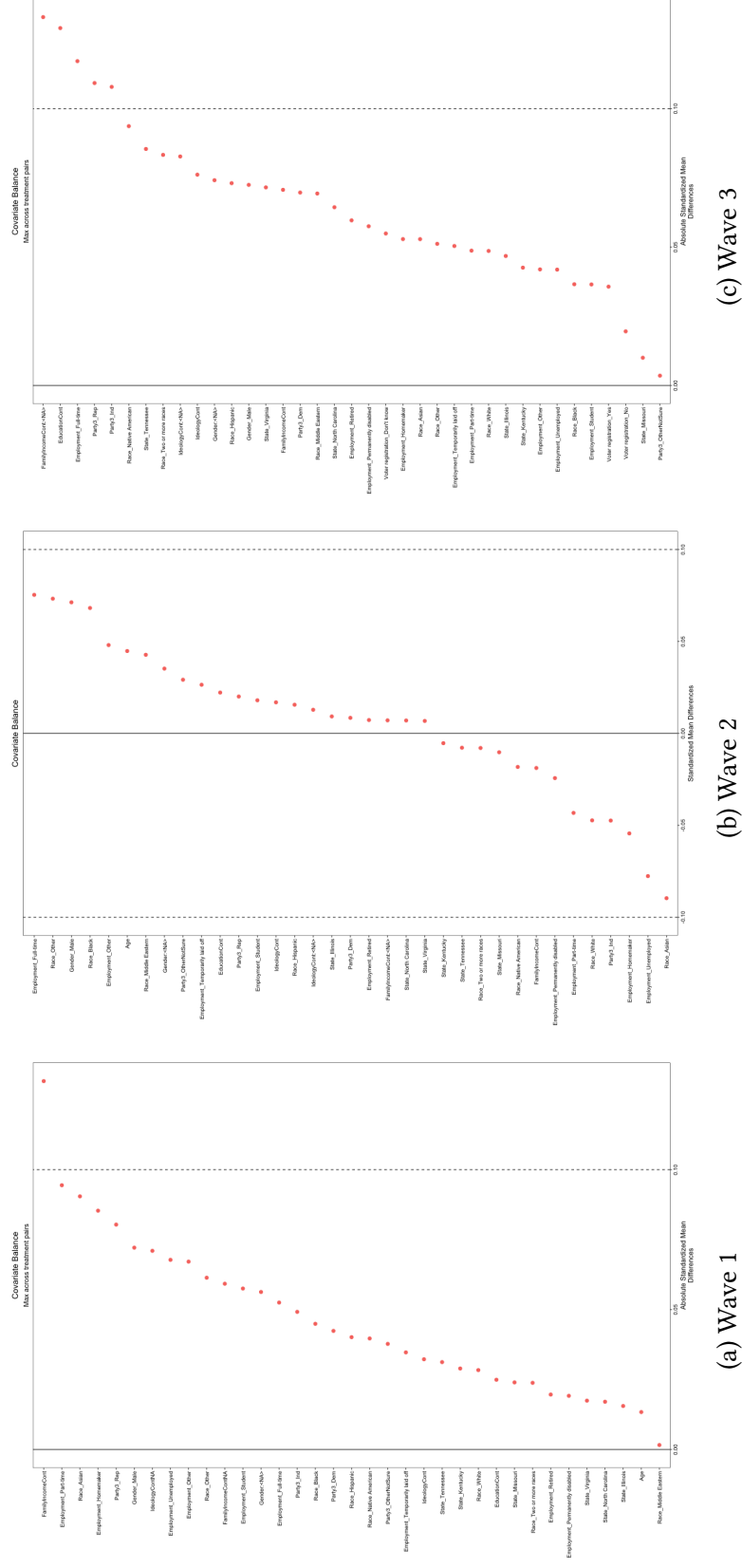


Figure A1: Covariate balance across treatment arms.

Notes: Each panel plots the maximum absolute standardized mean difference across treatment arms. For Wave 2 the plotted quantity is the signed standardized mean difference for the information arm versus control. The dashed line marks the 0.1 threshold used to classify imbalance (Stuart, Lee, and Leacy, 2013, S85). Variables exceeding that threshold in the plotted panels: Wave 1, family income continuous; Wave 2, none; Wave 3, missing family income, education continuous, full-time employment, and Republican and Independent party identification.

	Health policy		Labor market		Redistributive policy	
	Univ health	Free univ health	Job guarantee	+600 USD unemp	Wealth tax	Income tax
Minorities	-0.028 (0.021)	-0.013 (0.020)	Wave 1: main effects (pooled) -0.011 (0.019)	-0.037* (0.021)	-0.047** (0.020)	-0.038* (0.021)
Poor	-0.041* (0.022)	-0.010 (0.020)	-0.024 (0.019)	-0.024 (0.021)	-0.014 (0.020)	-0.008 (0.021)
Minorities × Republican	0.033 (0.049)	-0.035 (0.045)	Wave 1: treatment × Republican -0.026 (0.047)	0.008 (0.049)	-0.083* (0.047)	-0.083* (0.047)
Poor × Republican	0.017 (0.051)	-0.118*** (0.045)	-0.007 (0.049)	-0.011 (0.049)	0.000 (0.048)	-0.029 (0.048)
Minorities	-0.035 (0.024)	-0.003 (0.023)	Wave 1: total effect, non-Republicans -0.002 (0.020)	-0.038 (0.024)	-0.021 (0.022)	-0.012 (0.024)
Poor	-0.044* (0.025)	0.026 (0.023)	-0.021 (0.021)	-0.019 (0.024)	-0.013 (0.022)	0.001 (0.024)
Minorities	-0.002 (0.043)	-0.037 (0.038)	Wave 1: total effect, Republicans -0.028 (0.043)	-0.030 (0.043)	-0.104** (0.042)	-0.096** (0.040)
Poor	-0.027 (0.044)	-0.092** (0.038)	-0.028 (0.044)	-0.030 (0.043)	-0.013 (0.043)	-0.028 (0.042)
Affects Blacks	-0.028 (0.027)	-0.019 (0.027)	Wave 3: main effects (pooled) -0.008 (0.027)	-0.045 (0.028)	-0.050* (0.027)	-0.058** (0.028)
Affects Whites	-0.003 (0.027)	0.032 (0.027)	0.031 (0.027)	-0.022 (0.028)	0.002 (0.027)	-0.012 (0.027)
Affects Blacks × Republican	-0.066 (0.059)	0.013 (0.052)	Wave 3: treatment × Republican -0.022 (0.061)	-0.013 (0.056)	0.104* (0.059)	0.019 (0.058)
Affects Whites × Republican	-0.005 (0.060)	0.024 (0.053)	-0.068 (0.060)	-0.041 (0.056)	0.060 (0.058)	-0.001 (0.058)
Affects Blacks	0.001 (0.030)	-0.010 (0.032)	Wave 3: total effect, non-Republicans 0.006 (0.030)	-0.032 (0.032)	-0.068** (0.030)	-0.053* (0.031)
Affects Whites	0.013 (0.030)	0.044 (0.031)	0.064** (0.030)	0.006 (0.032)	0.003 (0.029)	0.005 (0.031)
Affects Blacks	-0.066 (0.051)	0.003 (0.041)	Wave 3: total effect, Republicans -0.016 (0.053)	-0.045 (0.046)	0.036 (0.050)	-0.034 (0.049)
Affects Whites	0.008 (0.051)	0.068 (0.042)	-0.004 (0.052)	-0.035 (0.046)	0.063 (0.050)	0.004 (0.049)

Table A1: Summary of main results

Notes: Ordinary least squares; dependent variables are agreement (0–1) with each policy. Full sample with race indicators (White omitted). Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses. Main effects (pooled) are from the main-effects specification. Treatment × Republican rows are the interaction coefficients (δ). Total effect, non-Republicans is the treatment coefficient (β) from the interaction model; total effect, Republicans is $\beta + \delta$, with standard errors from the estimated covariance matrix. Wave 1 controls: employment, ideology (linear score and “not sure” indicator), family income (linear score and “prefer not to say” indicator), and race. Wave 3 controls: employment, education (continuous), family income (linear score and missing-income indicator), and race. Full-coefficient versions are in Appendix Tables A2 and A3. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

	Univ health	Free univ health	Job guarantee	+600 USD unemp	Wealth tax	Income tax
<i>Panel A: Main effects</i>						
Minorities	-0.028 (0.021)	-0.013 (0.020)	-0.011 (0.019)	-0.037* (0.021)	-0.047** (0.020)	-0.038* (0.021)
Poor	-0.041* (0.022)	-0.010 (0.020)	-0.024 (0.019)	-0.024 (0.021)	-0.014 (0.020)	-0.008 (0.021)
Employment: Homemaker	0.005 (0.037)	0.053 (0.033)	0.002 (0.033)	0.025 (0.036)	0.031 (0.034)	-0.035 (0.035)
Employment: Other	-0.033 (0.064)	0.097* (0.057)	0.069 (0.050)	0.106* (0.057)	0.122** (0.056)	0.097* (0.058)
Employment: Part-time	0.069** (0.032)	-0.009 (0.031)	0.035 (0.029)	0.034 (0.031)	0.045 (0.030)	0.026 (0.031)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.026 (0.036)	0.093*** (0.033)	0.040 (0.031)	0.075** (0.036)	0.109*** (0.032)	0.046 (0.035)
Employment: Retired	-0.025 (0.025)	-0.088*** (0.022)	0.036* (0.023)	0.015 (0.024)	0.017 (0.023)	-0.022 (0.023)
Employment: Student	-0.031 (0.048)	0.006 (0.040)	-0.028 (0.039)	0.052 (0.040)	-0.003 (0.037)	-0.079* (0.042)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.068 (0.061)	0.034 (0.057)	0.051 (0.053)	0.214*** (0.053)	0.133** (0.055)	-0.044 (0.066)
Employment: Unemployed	0.021 (0.036)	0.077** (0.034)	0.044 (0.031)	0.117*** (0.035)	0.014 (0.033)	-0.038 (0.036)
IdeologyCont	-0.117*** (0.008)	-0.209*** (0.006)	-0.137*** (0.006)	-0.171*** (0.006)	-0.195*** (0.006)	-0.189*** (0.006)
IdeologyContNA	-0.356*** (0.041)	-0.606*** (0.037)	-0.496*** (0.036)	-0.622*** (0.039)	-0.693*** (0.038)	-0.657*** (0.039)
FamilyIncomeCont	0.014* (0.008)	-0.036*** (0.007)	-0.009 (0.007)	0.020*** (0.008)	-0.004 (0.007)	-0.038*** (0.008)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.103*** (0.039)	-0.226*** (0.034)	-0.129*** (0.035)	-0.027 (0.036)	-0.102*** (0.035)	-0.246*** (0.036)
Race: Asian	0.076 (0.070)	-0.071 (0.083)	-0.003 (0.068)	0.064 (0.070)	-0.032 (0.073)	-0.015 (0.074)
Race: Black	0.088*** (0.029)	0.068** (0.030)	0.024 (0.025)	0.106*** (0.029)	0.048* (0.028)	-0.022 (0.031)
Race: Hispanic	-0.058 (0.054)	-0.041 (0.048)	-0.137*** (0.051)	-0.022 (0.053)	-0.076 (0.050)	-0.155*** (0.052)
Race: Middle Eastern	-0.016 (0.242)	0.373*** (0.048)	-0.093 (0.297)	0.047 (0.266)	-0.007 (0.297)	0.033 (0.174)
Race: Native American	-0.210** (0.095)	-0.085 (0.077)	-0.189* (0.097)	-0.077 (0.085)	-0.160* (0.082)	-0.078 (0.097)
Race: Other	-0.071 (0.074)	-0.092 (0.067)	-0.135** (0.075)	-0.160* (0.068)	-0.136* (0.069)	-0.186*** (0.067)
Race: Two or more races	0.016 (0.066)	0.001 (0.061)	-0.049 (0.057)	-0.062 (0.060)	-0.009 (0.054)	-0.080 (0.061)
<i>Panel B: Treatment × Republican</i>						
Minorities	-0.035 (0.024)	-0.003 (0.023)	-0.002 (0.020)	-0.038 (0.024)	-0.021 (0.022)	-0.012 (0.024)
Poor	-0.044* (0.025)	0.026 (0.023)	-0.021 (0.021)	-0.019 (0.024)	-0.013 (0.022)	0.001 (0.024)
Republican	-0.116*** (0.039)	-0.063* (0.037)	-0.031 (0.038)	-0.088** (0.040)	-0.067* (0.039)	-0.066* (0.038)
Employment: Homemaker	0.005 (0.037)	0.052 (0.033)	0.002 (0.033)	0.025 (0.036)	0.033 (0.034)	-0.034 (0.036)
Employment: Other	-0.039 (0.063)	0.092* (0.054)	0.067 (0.050)	0.101* (0.057)	0.116*** (0.054)	0.091 (0.058)
Employment: Part-time	0.063*** (0.032)	-0.019 (0.031)	0.033 (0.029)	0.029 (0.031)	0.043 (0.030)	0.022 (0.031)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.022 (0.036)	0.086*** (0.032)	0.039 (0.031)	0.072** (0.035)	0.109*** (0.032)	0.044 (0.035)
Employment: Retired	-0.026 (0.023)	-0.090*** (0.022)	0.036 (0.023)	0.014 (0.024)	0.017 (0.023)	-0.022 (0.023)
Employment: Student	-0.029 (0.048)	0.008 (0.040)	-0.027 (0.039)	0.053 (0.040)	0.000 (0.037)	-0.076 (0.041)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.066 (0.062)	0.031 (0.058)	0.052 (0.052)	0.212*** (0.052)	0.136*** (0.054)	-0.042 (0.066)
Employment: Unemployed	0.022 (0.036)	0.079** (0.034)	0.044 (0.031)	0.118*** (0.035)	0.016 (0.033)	-0.036 (0.036)
IdeologyCont	-0.097*** (0.009)	-0.185*** (0.008)	-0.128*** (0.008)	-0.152*** (0.008)	-0.175*** (0.008)	-0.167*** (0.008)
IdeologyContNA	-0.307*** (0.043)	-0.551*** (0.038)	-0.476*** (0.038)	-0.579*** (0.040)	-0.646*** (0.039)	-0.606*** (0.041)
FamilyIncomeCont	0.014* (0.008)	-0.036*** (0.007)	-0.009 (0.007)	0.020*** (0.007)	-0.004 (0.007)	-0.038*** (0.008)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.105*** (0.039)	-0.225*** (0.033)	-0.130*** (0.035)	-0.028 (0.036)	-0.106*** (0.035)	-0.249*** (0.036)
Race: Asian	0.068 (0.069)	-0.084 (0.082)	-0.005 (0.068)	0.057 (0.071)	-0.037 (0.072)	-0.022 (0.074)
Race: Black	0.069** (0.029)	0.044 (0.030)	0.016 (0.026)	0.089*** (0.029)	0.029 (0.028)	-0.042 (0.031)
Race: Hispanic	-0.068 (0.054)	-0.056 (0.049)	-0.141*** (0.052)	-0.031 (0.053)	-0.085* (0.049)	-0.165*** (0.051)
Race: Middle Eastern	-0.037 (0.241)	0.349** (0.052)	-0.102 (0.297)	0.028 (0.268)	-0.028 (0.295)	0.011 (0.180)
Race: Native American	-0.214*** (0.095)	-0.089 (0.080)	-0.192** (0.097)	-0.081 (0.087)	-0.166** (0.084)	-0.084 (0.097)
Race: Other	-0.098 (0.075)	-0.127* (0.067)	-0.165** (0.076)	-0.184*** (0.069)	-0.158** (0.069)	-0.212*** (0.068)
Race: Two or more races	-0.001 (0.066)	-0.019 (0.061)	-0.056 (0.057)	-0.077 (0.060)	-0.024 (0.054)	-0.097 (0.062)
Minorities × Republican	0.033 (0.049)	-0.035 (0.045)	-0.026 (0.047)	0.008 (0.049)	-0.083* (0.047)	-0.083* (0.047)
Poor × Republican	0.017 (0.051)	-0.118*** (0.045)	-0.007 (0.049)	-0.011 (0.049)	0.000 (0.048)	-0.029 (0.048)

Table A2: Wave 1 canonical regressions (full sample with race indicators)

Notes: Ordinary least squares; dependent variables are agreement (0–1). Panel A is the main-effects specification; Panel B adds Republican identification and treatment × Republican interactions. Full sample with race indicators (White omitted). Controls are the Wave 1 canonical adjustment set (employment, ideology, family income). Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses; intercept omitted. Coefficients match the Wave 1 panels of Table A1. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

	Univ health	Free univ health	Job guarantee	+600 USD unemp	Wealth tax	Income tax
<i>Panel A: Main effects</i>						
Affects Blacks	-0.028 (0.027)	-0.019 (0.027)	-0.008 (0.027)	-0.045 (0.028)	-0.050* (0.027)	-0.058** (0.028)
Affects Whites	-0.003 (0.027)	0.032 (0.027)	0.031 (0.027)	-0.022 (0.028)	0.002 (0.027)	-0.012 (0.027)
Employment: Homemaker	-0.019 (0.048)	0.029 (0.048)	0.048 (0.046)	0.032 (0.047)	0.059 (0.047)	0.050 (0.048)
Employment: Other	0.107 (0.074)	0.093 (0.083)	0.040 (0.078)	0.174** (0.079)	0.189*** (0.072)	0.220*** (0.077)
Employment: Part-time	0.120*** (0.040)	0.106** (0.042)	0.032 (0.041)	0.152*** (0.042)	0.111*** (0.041)	0.110*** (0.041)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.094** (0.044)	0.137*** (0.044)	0.086** (0.042)	0.051 (0.045)	0.115*** (0.044)	0.111** (0.045)
Employment: Retired	0.014 (0.031)	-0.114*** (0.031)	-0.061** (0.031)	0.006 (0.031)	0.021 (0.031)	0.011 (0.031)
Employment: Student	0.226*** (0.057)	0.246*** (0.062)	0.136*** (0.063)	0.216*** (0.068)	0.228*** (0.060)	0.181*** (0.064)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.156* (0.083)	0.227*** (0.085)	0.119 (0.083)	0.287*** (0.079)	0.182*** (0.083)	0.147* (0.086)
Employment: Unemployed	0.120** (0.047)	0.193*** (0.047)	0.131*** (0.045)	0.175*** (0.049)	0.188*** (0.046)	0.174*** (0.048)
EducationCont	0.048*** (0.008)	0.053*** (0.008)	0.032*** (0.008)	0.059*** (0.008)	0.039*** (0.008)	0.048*** (0.008)
FamilyIncomeCont	-0.001 (0.010)	-0.030*** (0.011)	-0.020* (0.010)	-0.012 (0.011)	0.000 (0.010)	-0.034*** (0.011)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.160*** (0.050)	-0.208*** (0.048)	-0.244*** (0.050)	-0.205*** (0.049)	-0.151*** (0.049)	-0.300*** (0.049)
Race: Asian	0.109 (0.085)	0.099 (0.088)	0.154** (0.075)	-0.108 (0.085)	0.129* (0.077)	-0.051 (0.088)
Race: Black	0.159*** (0.036)	0.169*** (0.039)	0.129*** (0.036)	0.156*** (0.042)	0.104*** (0.037)	0.040 (0.040)
Race: Hispanic	0.062 (0.068)	0.074 (0.070)	0.065 (0.066)	0.098 (0.068)	0.007 (0.073)	-0.088 (0.072)
Race: Middle Eastern	0.482*** (0.029)	0.588*** (0.029)	0.435*** (0.029)	0.617*** (0.029)	0.488*** (0.029)	0.568*** (0.029)
Race: Native American	-0.275*** (0.106)	-0.154 (0.101)	-0.048 (0.108)	-0.019 (0.117)	-0.141 (0.109)	-0.197* (0.110)
Race: Other	-0.091 (0.090)	-0.156* (0.089)	-0.079 (0.085)	-0.221*** (0.080)	-0.166* (0.090)	-0.307*** (0.080)
Race: Two or more races	0.160** (0.079)	0.153 (0.094)	0.137 (0.086)	0.213*** (0.086)	0.098 (0.088)	0.147* (0.088)
<i>Panel B: Treatment × Republican</i>						
Affects Blacks	0.001 (0.030)	-0.010 (0.032)	0.006 (0.030)	-0.032 (0.032)	-0.068** (0.030)	-0.053* (0.031)
Affects Whites	0.013 (0.030)	0.044 (0.031)	0.064** (0.030)	0.006 (0.032)	0.003 (0.029)	0.005 (0.031)
Republican	-0.295*** (0.044)	-0.411*** (0.038)	-0.229*** (0.045)	-0.296*** (0.042)	-0.414*** (0.042)	-0.341*** (0.043)
Employment: Homemaker	-0.002 (0.047)	0.050 (0.044)	0.062 (0.045)	0.049 (0.046)	0.078* (0.046)	0.068 (0.047)
Employment: Other	0.073 (0.068)	0.053 (0.076)	0.011 (0.077)	0.140* (0.078)	0.156** (0.062)	0.186*** (0.071)
Employment: Part-time	0.079** (0.039)	0.055 (0.039)	0.000 (0.040)	0.112*** (0.040)	0.065** (0.039)	0.068* (0.039)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.090*** (0.042)	0.133*** (0.041)	0.083** (0.041)	0.047 (0.043)	0.112*** (0.041)	0.108** (0.042)
Employment: Retired	0.029 (0.029)	-0.094*** (0.028)	-0.049 (0.030)	0.022 (0.030)	0.039 (0.029)	0.027 (0.029)
Employment: Student	0.180*** (0.054)	0.184*** (0.060)	0.097 (0.062)	0.168*** (0.065)	0.169*** (0.059)	0.128** (0.058)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.103 (0.075)	0.161** (0.079)	0.072 (0.081)	0.232*** (0.079)	0.122 (0.077)	0.090 (0.090)
Employment: Unemployed	0.104** (0.046)	0.173*** (0.048)	0.119*** (0.044)	0.160*** (0.048)	0.169*** (0.047)	0.157*** (0.049)
EducationCont	0.033*** (0.008)	0.033*** (0.008)	0.019** (0.008)	0.043*** (0.008)	0.021** (0.008)	0.031*** (0.008)
FamilyIncomeCont	0.004 (0.010)	-0.024** (0.010)	-0.016 (0.010)	-0.007 (0.010)	0.006 (0.010)	-0.029*** (0.010)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.128*** (0.049)	-0.169*** (0.046)	-0.219*** (0.049)	-0.174*** (0.048)	-0.115*** (0.047)	-0.267*** (0.048)
Race: Asian	0.056 (0.083)	0.033 (0.087)	0.110 (0.076)	-0.160* (0.085)	0.071 (0.080)	-0.106 (0.090)
Race: Black	0.064* (0.036)	0.052 (0.040)	0.052 (0.036)	0.064 (0.042)	-0.001 (0.038)	-0.059 (0.041)
Race: Hispanic	0.005 (0.068)	0.004 (0.069)	0.019 (0.067)	0.043 (0.070)	-0.055 (0.073)	-0.147*** (0.068)
Race: Middle Eastern	0.344*** (0.030)	0.431*** (0.031)	0.336*** (0.030)	0.494*** (0.032)	0.361*** (0.031)	0.440*** (0.032)
Race: Native American	-0.293** (0.118)	-0.177 (0.116)	-0.063 (0.120)	-0.037 (0.115)	-0.164 (0.125)	-0.217* (0.114)
Race: Other	-0.167* (0.091)	-0.251*** (0.086)	-0.142* (0.082)	-0.296*** (0.079)	-0.251*** (0.092)	-0.387*** (0.083)
Race: Two or more races	0.060 (0.081)	0.028 (0.094)	0.052 (0.087)	0.112 (0.087)	-0.014 (0.088)	0.041 (0.090)
Affects Blacks × Republican	-0.066 (0.059)	0.013 (0.052)	-0.022 (0.061)	-0.013 (0.056)	0.104* (0.059)	0.019 (0.058)
Affects Whites × Republican	-0.005 (0.060)	0.024 (0.053)	-0.068 (0.060)	-0.041 (0.056)	0.060 (0.058)	-0.001 (0.058)

Table A3: Wave 3 canonical regressions (full sample with race indicators)

Notes: Ordinary least squares; dependent variables are agreement (0–1). Panel A is the main-effects specification; Panel B adds Republican identification and treatment × Republican interactions. Full sample with race indicators (White omitted). Controls are the Wave 3 canonical adjustment set (employment, education, family income). Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses; intercept omitted. Coefficients match the Wave 3 panels of Table A1. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Online Appendix

OA.1 Additional figures

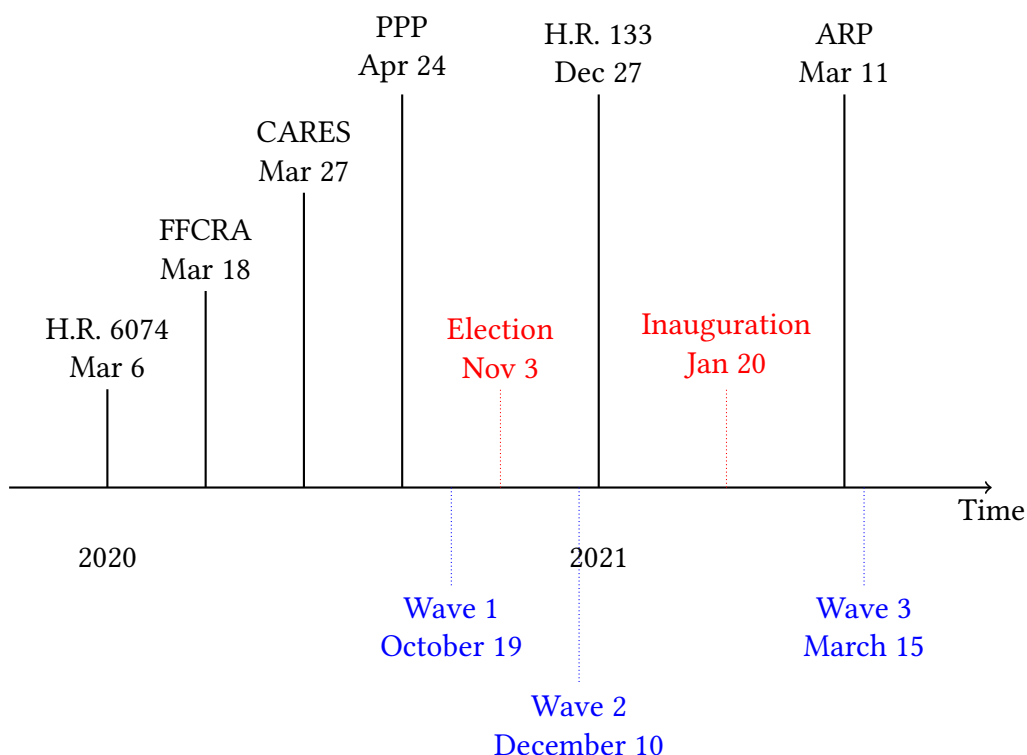


Figure OA.1: Timeline of COVID relief policies

Note: timing of COVID-19 relief bills, electoral dates, and survey waves. Amounts: Coronavirus Preparedness and Response Supplemental Appropriations Act, 2020 (H.R. 6074 - \$8.3 billion), Families First Coronavirus Response Act (FFCRA - \$104 billion), Coronavirus Aid, Relief, and Economic Security Act (CARES - \$2.2 trillion), Paycheck Protection Program and Health Care Enhancement Act (PPP - \$484 billion), Consolidated Appropriations Act, 2021 (H.R. 133 - \$900 billion), and American Rescue Plan Act of 2021 (ARP - \$1.9 trillion). FFCRA introduced 14-day paid leave for workers affected by the pandemic.

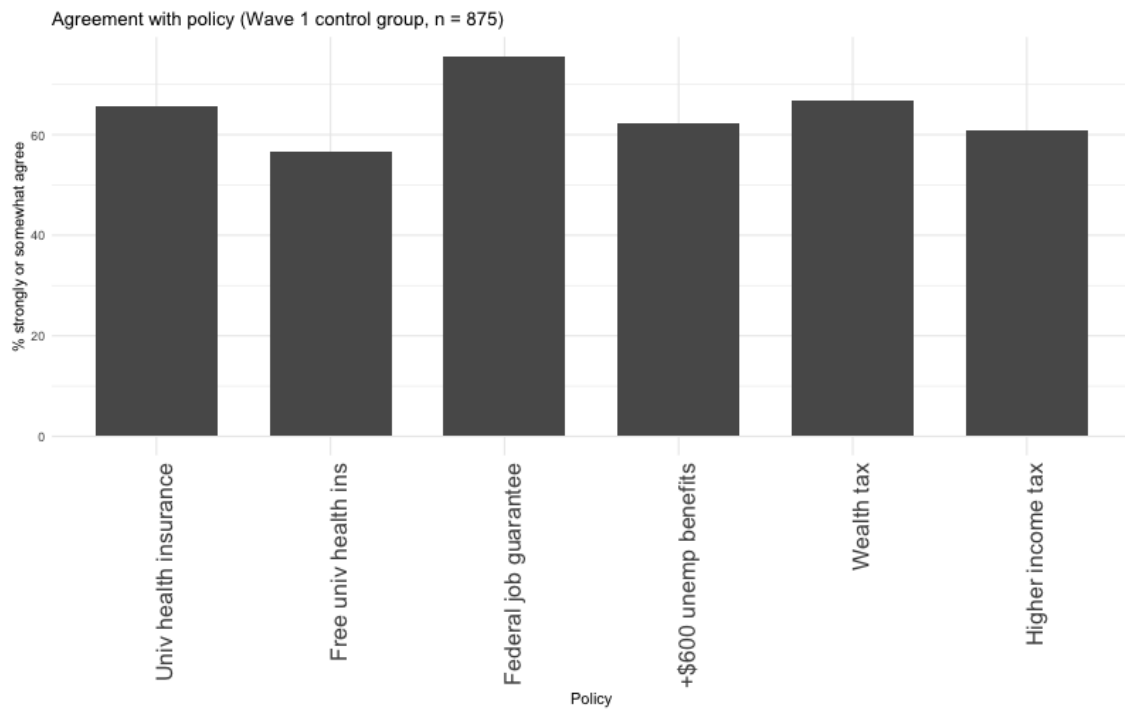


Figure OA.2: Baseline agreement with policy proposals among control group respondents

Note: mean agreement with each of the six policy proposals among Wave 1 control-group respondents ($n = 875$).

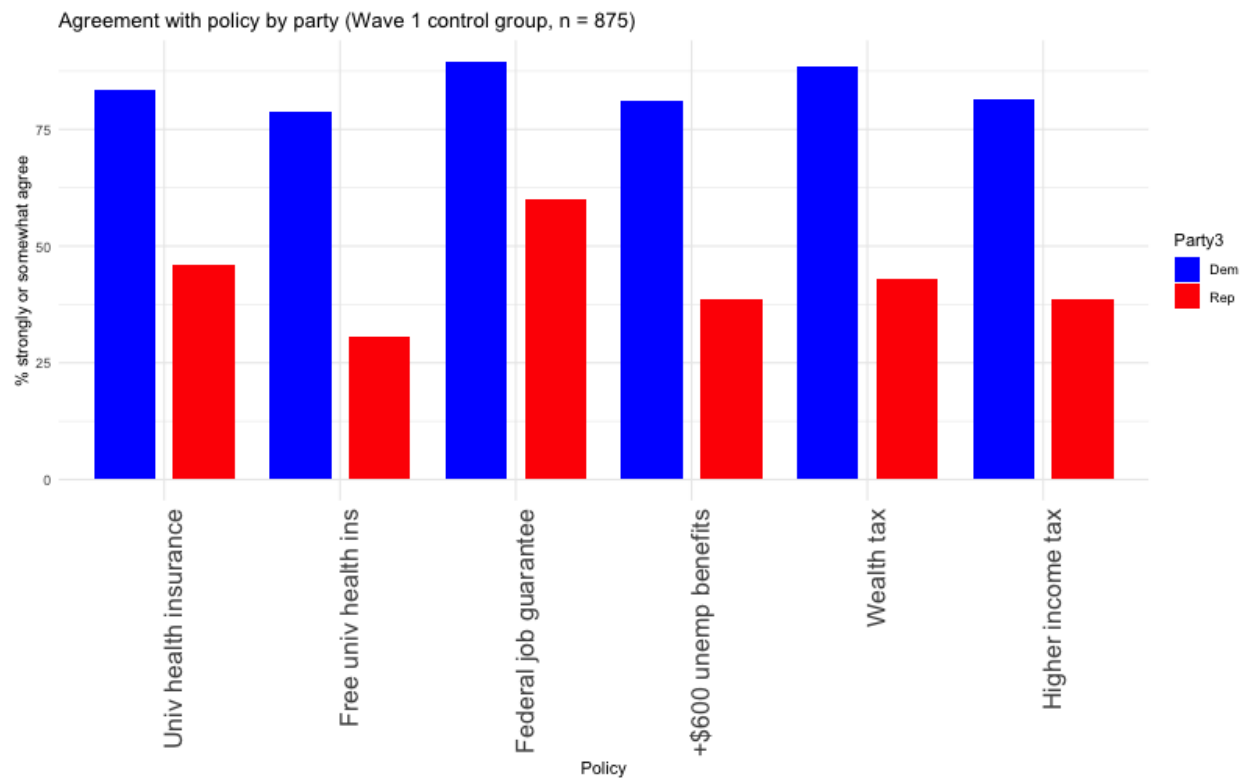


Figure OA.3: Baseline agreement with policy proposals, by party

Note: mean agreement with each of the six policy proposals among Wave 1 control-group respondents ($n = 875$), split by three-category party identification (Democrats and Republicans shown).

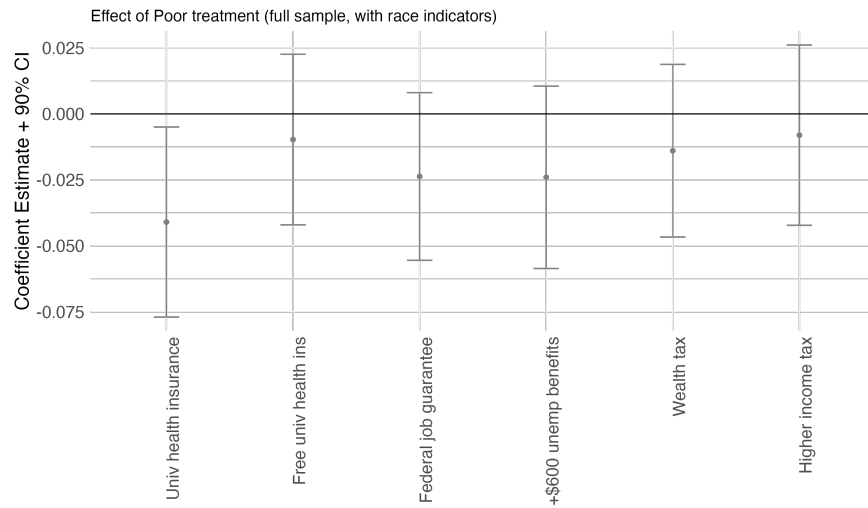


Figure OA.4: Poor treatment in wave 1

Note: this figure plots the treatment-effect coefficients and 90% confidence intervals for the Poor treatment in Wave 1, estimated on the full sample with race indicators. Canonical specification per Equation 4: employment, ideology, family-income, and race controls; heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors.

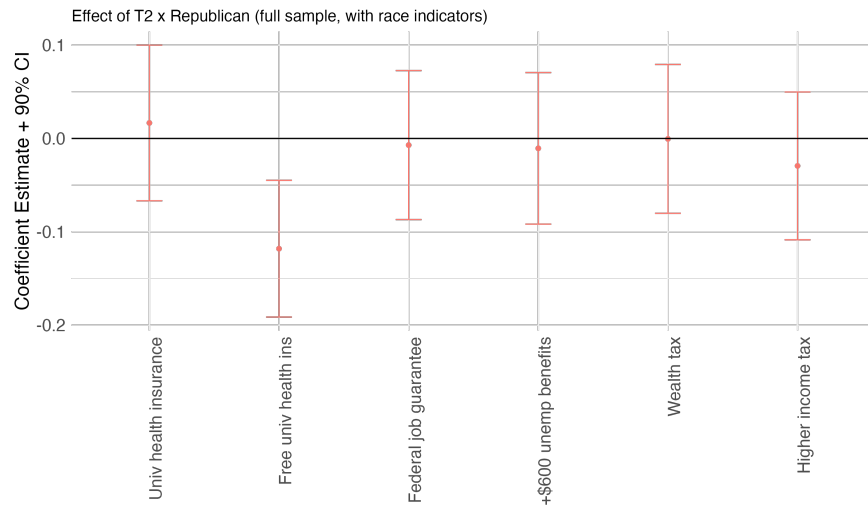


Figure OA.5: Poor treatment in wave 1 by party

Note: this figure plots the coefficients and 90% confidence intervals on the interaction between the Poor treatment indicator in Wave 1 and an indicator for Republican identification, estimated on the full sample with race indicators. Canonical specification per Equation 4: employment, ideology, family-income, and race controls; heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors.

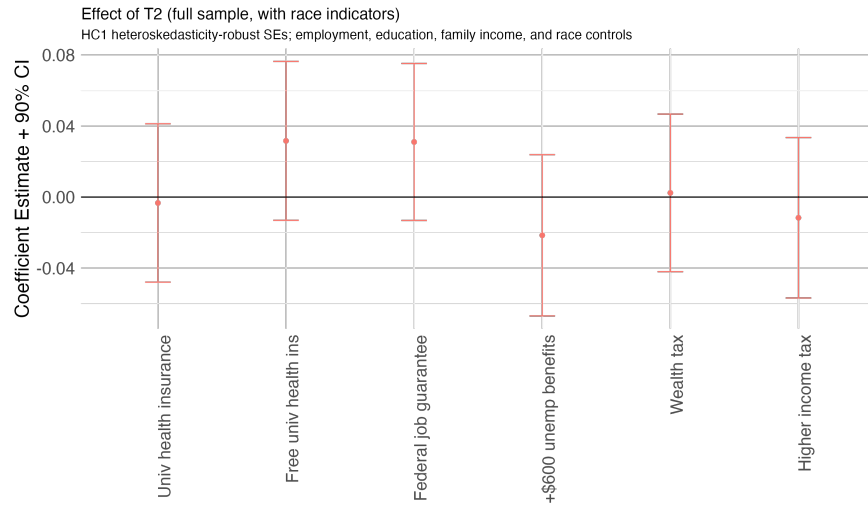


Figure OA.6: White treatment in wave 3

Note: this figure plots the treatment-effect coefficients and 90% confidence intervals for the “affects-Whites” treatment in Wave 3, estimated on the full sample with race indicators. Canonical specification per Equation 4: employment, education, family-income, and race controls; heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors.

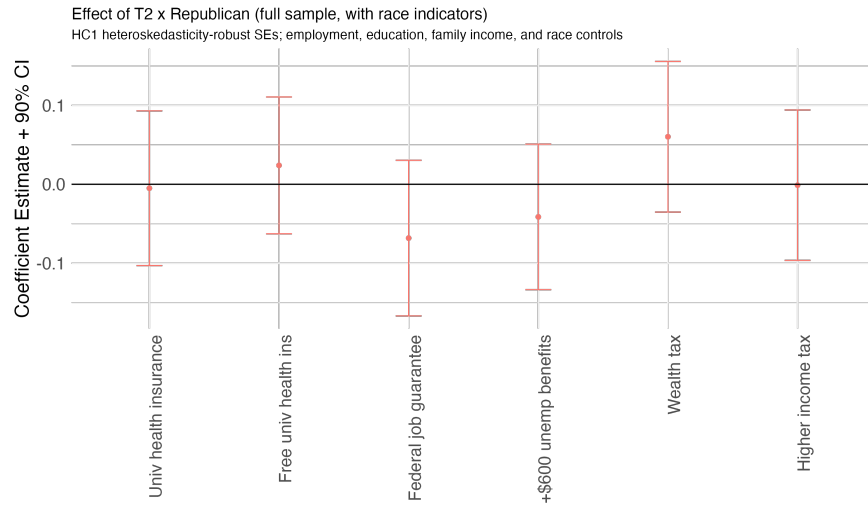


Figure OA.7: “affects-Whites” treatment in wave 3 by party

Note: this figure plots the coefficients and 90% confidence intervals on the interaction between the “affects-Whites” treatment indicator in Wave 3 and an indicator for Republican identification, estimated on the full sample with race indicators. Canonical specification per Equation 4: employment, education, family-income, and race controls; heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors.

OA.2 Supplemental tables and figures

OA.2.1 Wave 1 results

Table OA.1: Covariate balance table across the three treatment arms in Wave 1 survey

	Control (N = 875)	Black and Hispanic treatment (N = 918)	Poverty treatment (N = 907)
Gender			
Female	521 (60)	524 (57)	510 (57)
Male	345 (40)	389 (43)	391 (43)
Unknown/Missing	9 (1.03%)	5 (0.54%)	6 (0.66%)
Race			
White	715 (82)	755 (82)	736 (81)
Asian	19 (2)	10 (1)	10 (1)
Black	80 (9)	88 (10)	95 (10)
Hispanic	27 (3)	26 (3)	22 (2)
Middle Eastern	1 (0)	1 (0)	1 (0)
Native American	8 (1)	9 (1)	12 (1)
Other	10 (1)	12 (1)	17 (2)
Two or more races	15 (2)	17 (2)	14 (2)
Education			
No HS	31 (4)	40 (4)	45 (5)
2-year	86 (10)	94 (10)	97 (11)
4-year	178 (20)	196 (21)	184 (20)
High school graduate	273 (31)	271 (30)	271 (30)
Post-grad	114 (13)	116 (13)	113 (12)
Some college	193 (22)	201 (22)	197 (22)
Employment			
Full-time	325 (37)	338 (37)	314 (35)
Homemaker	58 (7)	75 (8)	81 (9)
Other	16 (2)	26 (3)	20 (2)
Part-time	78 (9)	75 (8)	99 (11)
Permanently disabled	80 (9)	79 (9)	78 (9)
Retired	185 (21)	188 (20)	193 (21)
Student	32 (4)	44 (5)	34 (4)
Temporarily laid off	19 (2)	24 (3)	19 (2)
Unemployed	82 (9)	69 (8)	69 (8)
Family income			
\$120,000 or more	105 (12)	126 (14)	100 (11)
\$20,000 - \$39,999	190 (22)	191 (21)	189 (21)
\$40,000 - \$59,999	157 (18)	149 (16)	152 (17)
\$60,000 - \$119,999	211 (24)	235 (26)	206 (23)
Less than \$20,000	129 (15)	133 (14)	161 (18)
Prefer not to say	83 (9)	84 (9)	99 (11)
Party			
Independent	105 (12)	125 (14)	127 (14)
Lean Democrat	98 (11)	88 (10)	73 (8)
Lean Republican	86 (10)	77 (8)	71 (8)
Not sure	33 (4)	33 (4)	40 (4)
Not very strong Democrat	80 (9)	75 (8)	86 (9)
Not very strong Republican	83 (9)	74 (8)	78 (9)
Strong Democrat	238 (27)	240 (26)	242 (27)
Strong Republican	152 (17)	206 (22)	190 (21)
Ideology			
Moderate	264 (30)	249 (27)	270 (30)
Conservative	165 (19)	169 (18)	171 (19)
Liberal	151 (17)	148 (16)	149 (16)
Not sure	62 (7)	83 (9)	79 (9)
Very conservative	102 (12)	142 (15)	119 (13)
Very liberal	131 (15)	127 (14)	119 (13)
Age			
minimum	18.00	18.00	18.00
median (IQR)	50.00 (36.00, 62.00)	50.00 (35.00, 62.00)	49.00 (35.00, 63.00)
mean (sd)	49.15 ± 16.64	49.00 ± 16.84	49.22 ± 16.91
maximum	94.00	88.00	95.00

	Univ health	Free univ health	Job guarantee	+600 USD unemp	Wealth tax	Income tax
Minorities	-0.018 (0.024)	-0.004 (0.022)	-0.004 (0.021)	-0.043* (0.023)	-0.034 (0.021)	-0.031 (0.022)
Poor	-0.047* (0.025)	-0.029 (0.022)	-0.044** (0.021)	-0.051** (0.023)	-0.032 (0.022)	-0.015 (0.023)
Employment: Homemaker	0.020 (0.040)	0.059* (0.035)	0.013 (0.035)	0.028 (0.039)	0.039 (0.037)	-0.026 (0.038)
Employment: Other	0.008 (0.070)	0.104* (0.063)	0.083 (0.055)	0.133** (0.064)	0.152** (0.061)	0.124* (0.065)
Employment: Part-time	0.074** (0.035)	-0.029 (0.034)	0.041 (0.031)	0.020 (0.035)	0.051 (0.033)	0.010 (0.034)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.019 (0.040)	0.069** (0.035)	0.017 (0.033)	0.049 (0.039)	0.099*** (0.034)	0.023 (0.037)
Employment: Retired	-0.021 (0.027)	-0.095*** (0.023)	0.044* (0.025)	0.006 (0.026)	0.014 (0.024)	-0.032 (0.024)
Employment: Student	-0.044 (0.058)	-0.018 (0.045)	-0.041 (0.044)	0.004 (0.046)	-0.034 (0.044)	-0.050 (0.049)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.079 (0.070)	0.022 (0.062)	0.036 (0.060)	0.200*** (0.060)	0.122* (0.063)	-0.058 (0.072)
Employment: Unemployed	0.032 (0.041)	0.081** (0.039)	0.066* (0.035)	0.105*** (0.040)	0.032 (0.038)	-0.031 (0.040)
IdeologyCont	-0.121*** (0.008)	-0.215*** (0.006)	-0.142*** (0.007)	-0.177*** (0.007)	-0.201*** (0.006)	-0.193*** (0.007)
IdeologyContNA	-0.346*** (0.048)	-0.585*** (0.042)	-0.487*** (0.041)	-0.628*** (0.046)	-0.698*** (0.044)	-0.656*** (0.045)
FamilyIncomeCont	0.015 (0.009)	-0.046*** (0.008)	-0.016** (0.008)	0.017** (0.008)	-0.016** (0.008)	-0.049*** (0.008)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.106** (0.043)	-0.251*** (0.036)	-0.150*** (0.039)	-0.033 (0.040)	-0.152*** (0.039)	-0.301*** (0.040)

Table OA.2: Wave 1 treatment effects (White respondents)

Notes: Ordinary least squares. Sample restricted to White respondents (robustness to the full-sample main summary). Dependent variables are agreement (0–1) with each policy in the column heading. The omitted category for treatment is control; the omitted category for employment is full-time. Canonical adjustment set (employment, ideology, family-income); race is omitted because the sample is restricted to White respondents. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; intercept omitted. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

	Univ health	Free univ health	Job guarantee	+600 USD unemp	Wealth tax	Income tax
Minorities	-0.030 (0.028)	0.008 (0.026)	0.009 (0.022)	-0.047* (0.026)	-0.001 (0.023)	0.008 (0.026)
Poor	-0.047 (0.029)	0.008 (0.026)	-0.043* (0.023)	-0.049* (0.027)	-0.039 (0.025)	-0.001 (0.027)
Republican	-0.100** (0.042)	-0.054 (0.039)	-0.008 (0.039)	-0.070* (0.042)	-0.064 (0.041)	-0.028 (0.041)
Employment: Homemaker	0.019 (0.040)	0.056 (0.036)	0.014 (0.035)	0.027 (0.039)	0.042 (0.037)	-0.024 (0.038)
Employment: Other	0.004 (0.068)	0.100* (0.060)	0.082 (0.055)	0.130** (0.063)	0.147** (0.059)	0.120* (0.064)
Employment: Part-time	0.068* (0.036)	-0.039 (0.033)	0.040 (0.032)	0.016 (0.035)	0.049 (0.033)	0.006 (0.034)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.017 (0.040)	0.064* (0.035)	0.018 (0.033)	0.047 (0.038)	0.102*** (0.034)	0.024 (0.037)
Employment: Retired	-0.024 (0.027)	-0.099*** (0.023)	0.044* (0.025)	0.004 (0.026)	0.013 (0.024)	-0.033 (0.024)
Employment: Student	-0.045 (0.058)	-0.020 (0.045)	-0.040 (0.044)	0.003 (0.047)	-0.031 (0.044)	-0.048 (0.049)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.075 (0.071)	0.018 (0.064)	0.038 (0.060)	0.198*** (0.060)	0.126** (0.063)	-0.055 (0.072)
Employment: Unemployed	0.032 (0.040)	0.081** (0.038)	0.066* (0.035)	0.105*** (0.040)	0.032 (0.038)	-0.031 (0.040)
IdeologyCont	-0.102*** (0.010)	-0.192*** (0.008)	-0.137*** (0.009)	-0.162*** (0.009)	-0.180*** (0.009)	-0.173*** (0.009)
IdeologyContNA	-0.301*** (0.050)	-0.534*** (0.043)	-0.476*** (0.044)	-0.593*** (0.047)	-0.649*** (0.046)	-0.613*** (0.047)
FamilyIncomeCont	0.015 (0.009)	-0.046*** (0.008)	-0.016** (0.008)	0.017** (0.008)	-0.017** (0.008)	-0.049*** (0.008)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.106** (0.043)	-0.249*** (0.036)	-0.152*** (0.039)	-0.034 (0.040)	-0.158*** (0.039)	-0.305*** (0.040)
Minorities × Republican	0.039 (0.052)	-0.035 (0.047)	-0.038 (0.049)	0.013 (0.052)	-0.097** (0.049)	-0.117** (0.049)
Poor × Republican	0.008 (0.054)	-0.103** (0.047)	-0.004 (0.050)	-0.001 (0.052)	0.021 (0.051)	-0.040 (0.050)

Table OA.3: Wave 1 treatment × Republican (White respondents)

Notes: Same canonical specification as the summary table's treatment × Republican rows, restricted to White respondents as a robustness check. Race is omitted because the sample is all-White. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; intercept omitted. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

OA.2.2 Wave 2

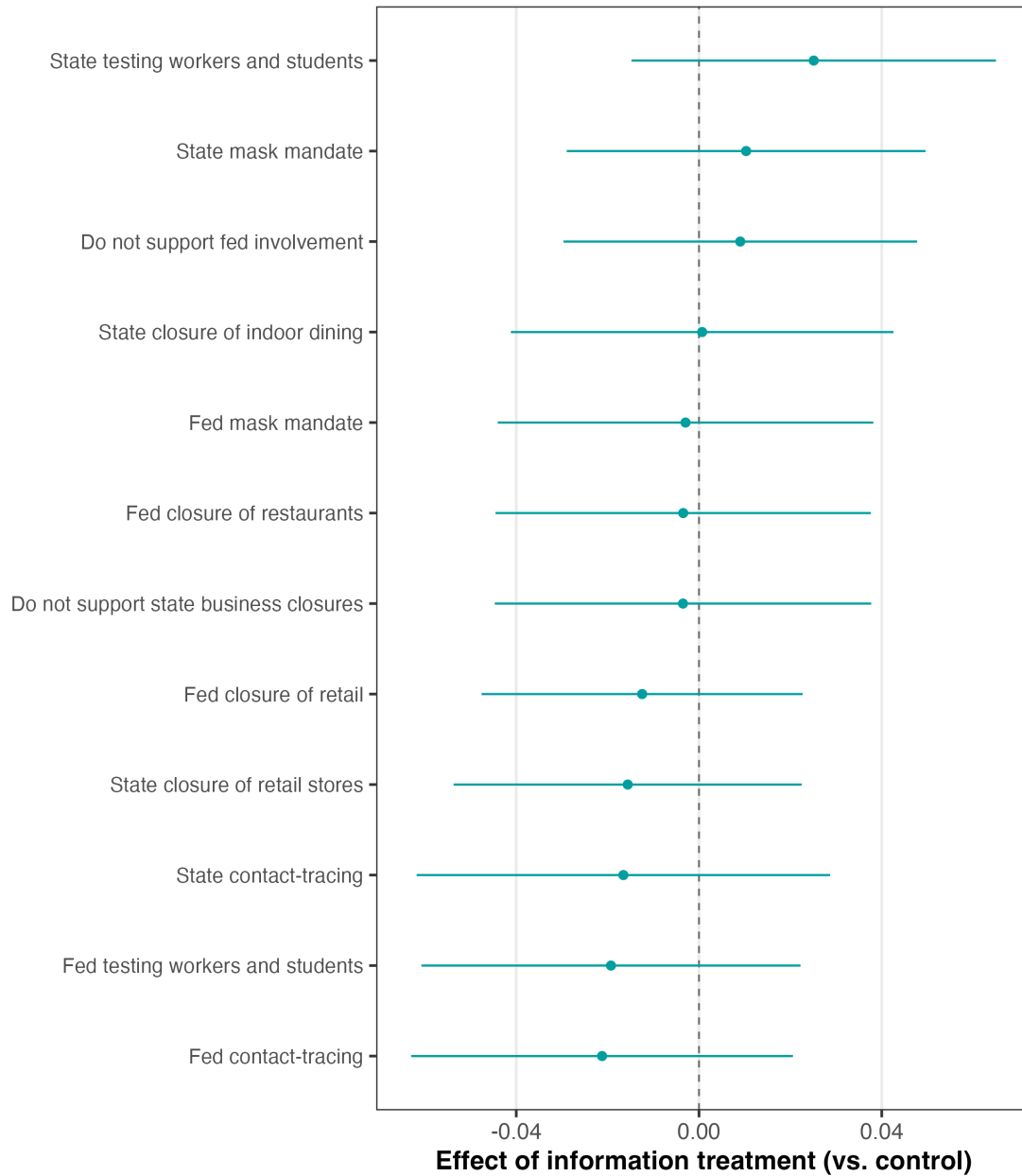


Figure OA.8: Wave 2 treatment effects on policy agreement

Note: Estimated effect of exposing respondents to the actual number of COVID-19 cases and deaths in their state on agreement with each policy ($n = 2,183$). Ordinary least squares with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; each outcome is regressed on the information treatment indicator only (no controls). Points are ordered by estimated effect; bars show 95% confidence intervals.

	State mask mandate	State testing workers and students	State closure of indoor dining	State closure of retail stores	Do not support state business closures	State contact- tracing	Fed mask mandate	Fed testing workers and students	Fed closure of restaurants	Fed closure of retail stores	Fed contact- tracing	Do not support fed involvement
infor_treat: 1	0.020 (0.017)	0.031* (0.019)	0.009 (0.018)	-0.007 (0.018)	-0.015 (0.017)	-0.017 (0.019)	0.006 (0.017)	-0.011 (0.019)	0.005 (0.018)	-0.006 (0.017)	-0.012 (0.018)	0.000 (0.016)
Party3: Dem	0.116** (0.022)	0.124** (0.025)	0.132** (0.027)	0.088** (0.028)	-0.102** (0.024)	0.163** (0.027)	0.149** (0.024)	0.107** (0.026)	0.127** (0.029)	0.081** (0.026)	0.161** (0.028)	-0.133** (0.021)
Party3: OtherNotSure	0.039* (0.023)	0.043 (0.025)	0.043 (0.025)	0.043 (0.025)	0.040 (0.024)	0.047 (0.024)	0.042 (0.024)	0.043 (0.026)	0.049 (0.027)	0.046 (0.026)	0.042 (0.026)	0.040 (0.021)
Party3: Rep	-0.106** (0.029)	-0.048 (0.030)	-0.148** (0.031)	-0.067** (0.028)	0.184** (0.040)	-0.051 (0.047)	-0.170** (0.042)	-0.105** (0.043)	-0.107** (0.043)	-0.102** (0.043)	-0.078** (0.043)	0.111** (0.040)
IdeologyCont	-0.146** (0.008)	-0.116** (0.010)	-0.154** (0.010)	-0.117** (0.010)	0.152** (0.009)	-0.158** (0.010)	-0.147** (0.009)	-0.133** (0.010)	-0.138** (0.010)	-0.102** (0.010)	-0.145** (0.010)	0.133** (0.009)
IdeologyContNA	-0.434** (0.047)	-0.349** (0.053)	-0.530** (0.054)	-0.425** (0.052)	0.373** (0.050)	-0.382** (0.060)	-0.406** (0.051)	-0.396** (0.055)	-0.399** (0.055)	-0.329** (0.052)	-0.476** (0.054)	0.346** (0.045)
EducationCont	0.009 (0.006)	0.007 (0.007)	0.016** (0.007)	0.005 (0.007)	0.001 (0.006)	0.015** (0.007)	0.002 (0.006)	0.000 (0.007)	-0.006 (0.006)	-0.007 (0.006)	0.023** (0.007)	-0.002 (0.006)
Employment:	0.030 (0.038)	0.046 (0.040)	0.065 (0.042)	0.034 (0.039)	-0.090** (0.043)	0.060 (0.044)	0.035 (0.040)	-0.005 (0.043)	0.098** (0.043)	0.049 (0.038)	0.059 (0.041)	-0.044 (0.038)
Homemaker	0.053 (0.053)	0.063 (0.063)	0.063 (0.063)	0.021 (0.063)	0.043 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)
Employment: Other	0.053 (0.053)	0.063 (0.063)	0.063 (0.063)	0.021 (0.063)	0.043 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)
Employment: Part-time	0.053 (0.053)	0.063 (0.063)	0.063 (0.063)	0.021 (0.063)	0.043 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)	0.086 (0.063)
Employment:	0.071* (0.031)	0.072* (0.035)	0.096** (0.035)	0.038 (0.036)	-0.066** (0.036)	0.071* (0.036)	0.069** (0.036)	0.091** (0.035)	0.068* (0.036)	0.049 (0.033)	0.141** (0.033)	-0.075** (0.031)
Permanently disabled	0.032 (0.032)	0.039 (0.039)	0.035 (0.035)	0.036 (0.036)	0.033 (0.033)	0.039 (0.039)	0.033 (0.033)	0.038 (0.038)	0.037 (0.037)	0.035 (0.035)	0.037 (0.037)	0.032 (0.032)
Employment: Retired	0.040* (0.023)	0.114** (0.026)	0.053** (0.023)	-0.030 (0.023)	-0.031 (0.023)	0.121** (0.027)	0.052** (0.023)	0.079** (0.026)	0.016 (0.024)	-0.053** (0.021)	0.075** (0.025)	-0.038 (0.023)
Employment: Student	0.059 (0.036)	0.072 (0.046)	0.038 (0.051)	0.007 (0.054)	-0.091** (0.042)	-0.033 (0.056)	0.024 (0.046)	0.067 (0.050)	0.074 (0.053)	0.055 (0.053)	0.028 (0.049)	-0.057 (0.043)
Employment:	-0.039 (0.061)	0.026 (0.073)	0.051 (0.071)	0.070 (0.073)	-0.157** (0.064)	0.021 (0.065)	0.037 (0.059)	0.026 (0.074)	0.024 (0.072)	0.032 (0.068)	0.017 (0.068)	-0.074 (0.066)
Temporarily laid off	0.061 (0.122)	0.073 (0.068)	0.071 (0.100)	0.073 (0.064)	-0.162** (0.036)	0.065 (0.044)	0.059 (0.119)	0.074 (0.101)	0.072 (0.111)	0.068 (0.068)	0.108** (0.068)	-0.122 (0.055)
Unemployed	0.037 (0.001)	0.040 (0.009)	0.040 (0.009)	0.041 (0.009)	0.036 (0.008)	0.044 (0.009)	0.039 (0.008)	0.041 (0.009)	0.042 (0.009)	0.040 (0.008)	0.042 (0.009)	0.035 (0.008)
FamilyIncomeCont	0.001 (0.008)	0.009 (0.009)	0.020** (0.009)	0.011 (0.009)	-0.007 (0.008)	-0.001 (0.009)	0.001 (0.008)	0.012 (0.009)	-0.004 (0.008)	0.010 (0.008)	0.026** (0.008)	0.000 (0.008)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.092* (0.058)	-0.077 (0.064)	0.011 (0.068)	0.011 (0.068)	0.007 (0.068)	-0.091** (0.082)	-0.071* (0.082)	-0.035 (0.082)	-0.020 (0.082)	-0.020 (0.082)	0.026 (0.082)	0.097** (0.082)
Race: Asian	0.158** (0.055)	0.064 (0.076)	0.096 (0.078)	0.096 (0.078)	-0.103** (0.056)	0.163** (0.082)	0.149** (0.073)	0.149** (0.076)	0.149** (0.078)	0.149** (0.078)	0.149** (0.083)	-0.07* (0.055)
Race: Black	0.059* (0.026)	-0.007 (0.032)	-0.059 (0.039)	-0.081** (0.038)	-0.011 (0.035)	-0.017 (0.038)	0.011 (0.031)	0.021 (0.035)	-0.012 (0.039)	-0.010 (0.036)	-0.122** (0.036)	-0.032 (0.027)
Race: Hispanic	-0.060 (0.054)	-0.061 (0.060)	-0.125** (0.061)	-0.105* (0.057)	0.028 (0.052)	-0.041 (0.063)	-0.068 (0.054)	-0.046 (0.062)	-0.136** (0.062)	-0.085 (0.055)	-0.128** (0.055)	0.077 (0.053)
Race: Middle Eastern	0.103** (0.028)	0.140** (0.033)	0.282** (0.033)	0.537** (0.034)	-0.191** (0.030)	0.214** (0.034)	0.142** (0.029)	0.232** (0.033)	0.418** (0.035)	0.641** (0.033)	0.311** (0.034)	-0.118** (0.027)
Race: Native American	-0.095 (0.095)	-0.103 (0.103)	-0.258** (0.103)	-0.032 (0.103)	0.140 (0.083)	-0.052 (0.083)	-0.102 (0.083)	-0.047** (0.083)	-0.183** (0.083)	-0.030 (0.083)	-0.167** (0.083)	0.169** (0.083)
Race: Other	-0.180** (0.076)	-0.145* (0.086)	-0.107 (0.078)	-0.164** (0.054)	0.146* (0.077)	-0.125 (0.084)	-0.236** (0.078)	-0.224** (0.079)	-0.128** (0.073)	-0.163** (0.039)	-0.087 (0.077)	0.162** (0.072)
Race: Two or more races	-0.050 (0.058)	-0.084 (0.074)	0.019 (0.068)	-0.027 (0.080)	-0.031 (0.056)	0.035 (0.072)	-0.066 (0.067)	-0.084 (0.073)	0.007 (0.071)	0.044 (0.076)	-0.035 (0.071)	0.047 (0.055)
Gender: Male	-0.051** (0.018)	-0.012 (0.020)	-0.012 (0.019)	-0.053** (0.019)	0.047** (0.018)	-0.005 (0.020)	-0.043** (0.018)	-0.033 (0.020)	-0.017 (0.019)	-0.024 (0.018)	-0.016 (0.019)	0.056** (0.017)
State: Kentucky	-0.030 (0.030)	-0.034 (0.032)	-0.022 (0.030)	0.042 (0.031)	-0.003 (0.030)	-0.070** (0.035)	-0.057* (0.030)	-0.038 (0.033)	-0.001 (0.031)	0.052 (0.029)	0.020 (0.032)	0.059* (0.029)
State: Missouri	-0.014 (0.029)	-0.014 (0.032)	-0.014 (0.030)	-0.014 (0.031)	-0.014 (0.030)	-0.014 (0.034)	-0.014 (0.029)	-0.014 (0.032)	-0.014 (0.031)	-0.014 (0.029)	-0.014 (0.032)	-0.014 (0.029)
State: North Carolina	0.006 (0.028)	0.062* (0.031)	0.045 (0.031)	0.007 (0.032)	-0.050* (0.030)	-0.023 (0.034)	0.009 (0.030)	0.005 (0.033)	0.034 (0.033)	0.020 (0.030)	0.050 (0.033)	0.007 (0.028)
State: Tennessee	-0.023 (0.029)	0.027 (0.032)	0.024 (0.031)	0.050 (0.032)	0.005 (0.031)	-0.008 (0.034)	-0.036 (0.034)	-0.016 (0.033)	0.004 (0.032)	0.012 (0.029)	0.049 (0.033)	0.055* (0.029)
State: Virginia	-0.015 (0.028)	0.013 (0.032)	-0.023 (0.031)	0.004 (0.031)	0.009 (0.029)	-0.050 (0.034)	-0.021 (0.028)	-0.020 (0.032)	-0.005 (0.032)	-0.005 (0.029)	0.015 (0.032)	0.047* (0.028)

Table OA.4: Wave 2 information treatment with covariates

Notes: Ordinary least squares with the information treatment entered as a factor and pre-treatment covariates (party, ideology, education, employment, income, race, gender, state). Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. Twelve public-health policy outcomes. Intercepts omitted. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

OA.2.3 Wave 3

Table OA.5: Covariate balance table across the three treatment arms in survey wave 3

	control (N = 620)	affects Blacks (N = 625)	affects Whites (N = 617)
Gender			
Female	332 (54)	352 (56)	353 (57)
Male	284 (46)	272 (44)	261 (43)
Unknown/Missing	4 (0.65%)	1 (0.16%)	3 (0.49%)
Race			
White	511 (82)	526 (84)	508 (82)
Asian	8 (1)	9 (1)	12 (2)
Black	57 (9)	51 (8)	55 (9)
Hispanic	20 (3)	13 (2)	14 (2)
Middle Eastern	0 (0)	1 (0)	0 (0)
Native American	10 (2)	6 (1)	4 (1)
Other	8 (1)	11 (2)	12 (2)
Two or more races	6 (1)	8 (1)	12 (2)
Education			
No HS	35 (6)	14 (2)	19 (3)
2-year	56 (9)	64 (10)	66 (11)
4-year	142 (23)	141 (23)	119 (19)
High school graduate	179 (29)	182 (29)	200 (32)
Post-grad	99 (16)	91 (15)	72 (12)
Some college	109 (18)	133 (21)	141 (23)
Employment			
Full-time	232 (37)	199 (32)	231 (37)
Homemaker	43 (7)	52 (8)	43 (7)
Other	13 (2)	16 (3)	12 (2)
Part-time	57 (9)	53 (8)	61 (10)
Permanently disabled	54 (9)	65 (10)	59 (10)
Retired	153 (25)	164 (26)	146 (24)
Student	17 (3)	20 (3)	16 (3)
Temporarily laid off	8 (1)	12 (2)	12 (2)
Unemployed	43 (7)	44 (7)	37 (6)
Family income			
\$120,000 or more	81 (13)	70 (11)	70 (11)
\$20,000 - \$39,999	121 (20)	121 (19)	143 (23)
\$40,000 - \$59,999	107 (17)	112 (18)	109 (18)
\$60,000 - \$119,999	163 (26)	171 (27)	160 (26)
Less than \$20,000	87 (14)	80 (13)	89 (14)
Prefer not to say	61 (10)	71 (11)	46 (7)
Party			
Independent	75 (12)	86 (14)	74 (12)
Lean Democrat	71 (11)	56 (9)	53 (9)
Lean Republican	62 (10)	60 (10)	53 (9)
Not sure	16 (3)	24 (4)	14 (2)
Not very strong Democrat	57 (9)	55 (9)	53 (9)
Not very strong Republican	51 (8)	66 (11)	52 (8)
Strong Democrat	171 (28)	154 (25)	172 (28)
Strong Republican	117 (19)	124 (20)	146 (24)
Ideology			
Moderate	177 (29)	181 (29)	160 (26)
Conservative	102 (16)	127 (20)	134 (22)
Liberal	112 (18)	100 (16)	98 (16)
Not sure	33 (5)	46 (7)	42 (7)
Very conservative	103 (17)	84 (13)	99 (16)
Very liberal	93 (15)	87 (14)	84 (14)
Age			
minimum	18.00	19.00	18.00
median (IQR)	53.50 (39.00, 64.00)	54.00 (41.00, 65.00)	54.00 (40.00, 64.00)
mean (sd)	52.00 ± 16.20	53.20 ± 15.51	52.27 ± 15.75
maximum	92.00	94.00	89.00

	Univ health	Free univ health	Job guarantee	+600 USD unemp	Wealth tax	Income tax
Affects Blacks	-0.047 (0.030)	-0.032 (0.030)	-0.019 (0.030)	-0.060** (0.030)	-0.059* (0.030)	-0.051* (0.030)
Affects Whites	-0.023 (0.030)	0.002 (0.030)	0.016 (0.030)	-0.026 (0.030)	-0.010 (0.030)	-0.018 (0.030)
Employment: Homemaker	0.004 (0.053)	0.055 (0.053)	0.046 (0.052)	0.045 (0.052)	0.053 (0.053)	0.042 (0.053)
Employment: Other	0.129 (0.084)	0.174** (0.088)	0.033 (0.087)	0.223*** (0.086)	0.192** (0.083)	0.243*** (0.085)
Employment: Part-time	0.128*** (0.045)	0.112** (0.046)	0.025 (0.046)	0.152*** (0.046)	0.111** (0.045)	0.103** (0.046)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.064 (0.050)	0.130*** (0.049)	0.076 (0.047)	0.057 (0.048)	0.100** (0.049)	0.092* (0.050)
Employment: Retired	0.001 (0.034)	-0.110*** (0.033)	-0.064* (0.034)	0.012 (0.034)	0.005 (0.034)	-0.011 (0.034)
Employment: Student	0.198*** (0.069)	0.225*** (0.074)	0.109 (0.076)	0.227*** (0.079)	0.200*** (0.071)	0.177** (0.074)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.155* (0.090)	0.275*** (0.087)	0.164* (0.084)	0.294*** (0.085)	0.177** (0.088)	0.151* (0.092)
Employment: Unemployed	0.104* (0.055)	0.216*** (0.054)	0.156*** (0.051)	0.194*** (0.056)	0.233*** (0.050)	0.214*** (0.053)
EducationCont	0.049*** (0.009)	0.057*** (0.009)	0.033*** (0.009)	0.068*** (0.009)	0.037*** (0.009)	0.043*** (0.009)
FamilyIncomeCont	-0.004 (0.012)	-0.034*** (0.012)	-0.025** (0.012)	-0.016 (0.012)	-0.012 (0.012)	-0.039*** (0.012)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.161*** (0.056)	-0.226*** (0.053)	-0.248*** (0.055)	-0.209*** (0.054)	-0.192*** (0.054)	-0.323*** (0.054)

Table OA.6: Wave 3 main effects (White respondents)

Notes: Same canonical Wave 3 specification as the main summary table (employment, education, family-income), restricted to White respondents as a robustness check. Race is omitted because the sample is all-White. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; intercept omitted from display. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

	Univ health	Free univ health	Job guarantee	+600 USD unemp	Wealth tax	Income tax
Affects Blacks	-0.017 (0.034)	-0.024 (0.036)	-0.010 (0.035)	-0.055 (0.037)	-0.083** (0.033)	-0.051 (0.035)
Affects Whites	-0.001 (0.034)	0.011 (0.036)	0.051 (0.034)	0.013 (0.037)	-0.007 (0.032)	-0.004 (0.035)
Republican	-0.312*** (0.046)	-0.442*** (0.040)	-0.256*** (0.047)	-0.312*** (0.044)	-0.442*** (0.044)	-0.362*** (0.044)
Employment: Homemaker	0.020 (0.052)	0.076 (0.049)	0.059 (0.051)	0.060 (0.051)	0.072 (0.051)	0.059 (0.051)
Employment: Other	0.090 (0.075)	0.128* (0.077)	0.000 (0.085)	0.185** (0.084)	0.152** (0.069)	0.205*** (0.076)
Employment: Part-time	0.079* (0.043)	0.051 (0.044)	-0.013 (0.044)	0.107** (0.044)	0.056 (0.043)	0.054 (0.043)
Employment: Permanently disabled	0.061 (0.047)	0.127*** (0.045)	0.073 (0.045)	0.054 (0.045)	0.099** (0.044)	0.090* (0.046)
Employment: Retired	0.016 (0.032)	-0.090*** (0.030)	-0.052 (0.033)	0.027 (0.032)	0.024 (0.032)	0.005 (0.032)
Employment: Student	0.126* (0.065)	0.134** (0.068)	0.050 (0.073)	0.157** (0.074)	0.116* (0.068)	0.102 (0.067)
Employment: Temporarily laid off	0.093 (0.079)	0.199** (0.080)	0.109 (0.081)	0.228*** (0.085)	0.107 (0.081)	0.087 (0.097)
Employment: Unemployed	0.073 (0.053)	0.176*** (0.054)	0.132*** (0.051)	0.164*** (0.055)	0.196*** (0.051)	0.182*** (0.055)
EducationCont	0.031*** (0.009)	0.034*** (0.008)	0.018** (0.009)	0.049*** (0.009)	0.015* (0.009)	0.023*** (0.009)
FamilyIncomeCont	0.002 (0.011)	-0.027** (0.011)	-0.021* (0.011)	-0.010 (0.011)	-0.005 (0.011)	-0.033*** (0.011)
FamilyIncomeContNA	-0.124** (0.054)	-0.180*** (0.050)	-0.218*** (0.055)	-0.173*** (0.053)	-0.151*** (0.051)	-0.285*** (0.052)
Affects Blacks × Republican	-0.050 (0.062)	0.025 (0.054)	0.003 (0.064)	0.019 (0.059)	0.118* (0.061)	0.038 (0.061)
Affects Whites × Republican	-0.015 (0.062)	0.043 (0.056)	-0.057 (0.063)	-0.059 (0.059)	0.059 (0.060)	0.016 (0.061)

Table OA.7: Wave 3 treatment × Republican (White respondents)

Notes: Same canonical Wave 3 specification as the main summary table's treatment × Republican rows, restricted to White respondents as a robustness check. Race is omitted because the sample is all-White. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; intercept omitted. Significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

OA.2.4 Specification robustness

This section reports the sensitivity of the main treatment-effect estimates to the choice of covariate adjustment. Raw treatment–control differences by subgroup appear in main-text Figure 5. All models use heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors and 90% confidence intervals. The canonical specification used in the main text (Appendix Table A1) appears as **S4** (“paper main”) in each ladder. The other specifications add controls cumulatively: **S0** is a bivariate regression of the outcome on treatment assignment with no controls; **S1** adds race indicators; **S2** adds gender and employment; **S3** adds family income and education; **S5** augments the paper main spec with party identification (Party3) and ideology; and **S6** (Wave 3 only) further adds the respondent’s own Wave-1 response to the same policy item as a baseline control. In the interaction models, Party3 is omitted from S5 (and S6, for Wave 3) to avoid collinearity with the moderator. Numbers on each point are the coefficient estimate; the label below each point reports the sample size retained under that specification’s covariate-completeness requirements.

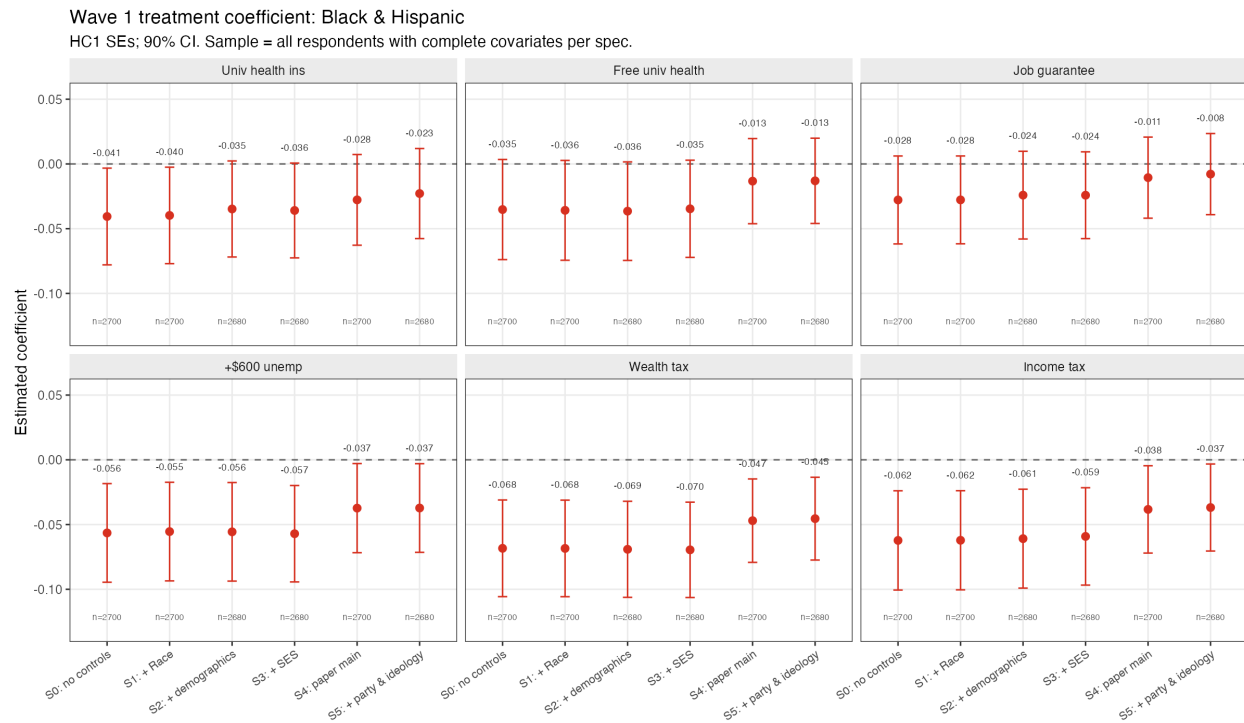


Figure OA.9: Wave 1 Black-and-Hispanic (T1) treatment coefficient across specifications

Note: Each panel plots the estimated coefficient on the Black-and-Hispanic treatment indicator (and 90% confidence interval) for one of the six policy outcomes, under six nested specifications S0–S5. Specification S4 is the canonical specification used in Appendix Table A1.

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; confidence intervals are for the treatment coefficient only. Sample sizes reflect complete-case covariate coverage for each specification.

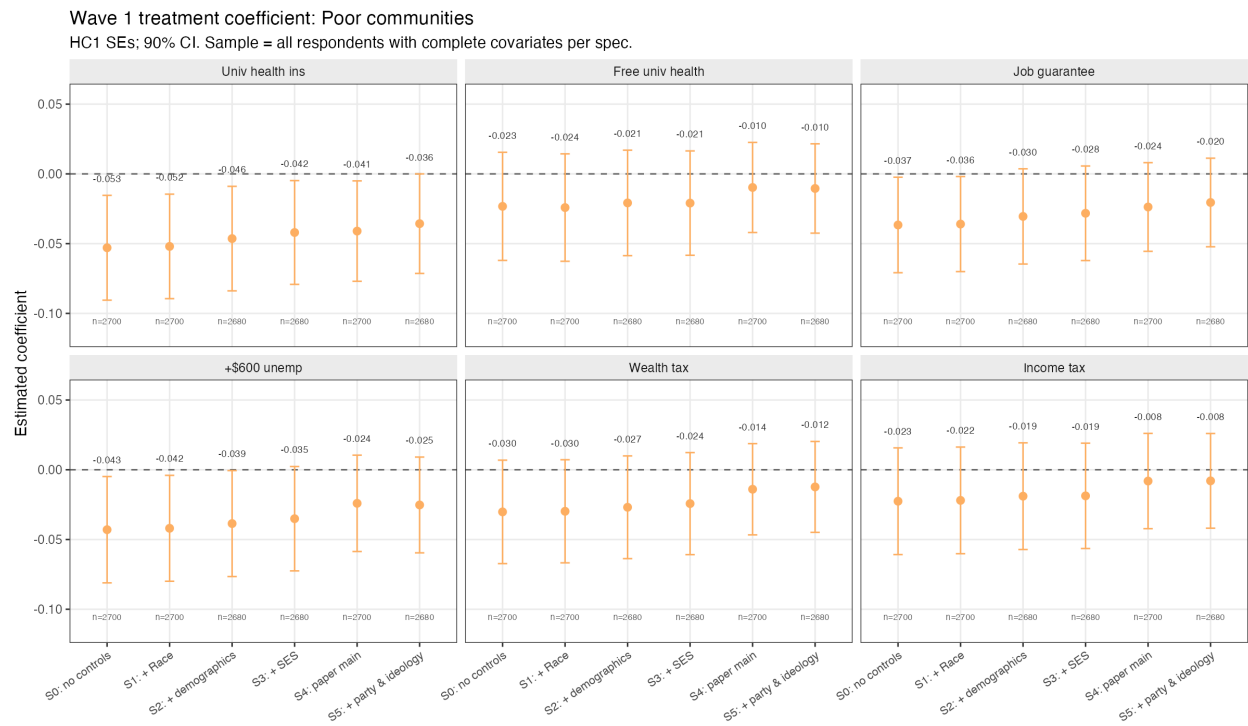


Figure OA.10: Wave 1 Poor-communities (T2) treatment coefficient across specifications

Note: As in Figure OA.9, for the Poor-communities treatment arm. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors; 90% confidence intervals.

Wave 1: Minorities .. Rep interaction coefficient

HC1 SEs; 90% CI. Interaction coefficient from $y \sim \text{treat} * \text{Rep} + \text{controls}$. S4 matches the paper's canonical specification; Party3 dropped in S5 (collinear with Rep). Wave

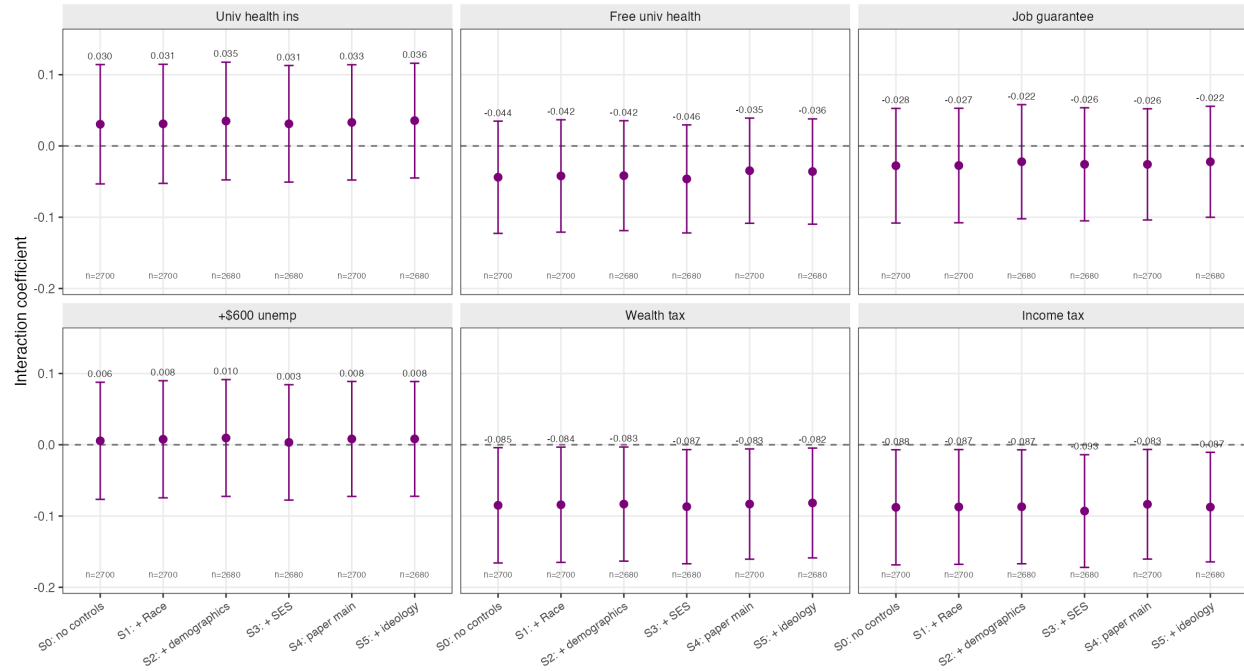


Figure OA.11: Wave 1 Minorities $\times$ Rep interaction coefficient across specifications

Note: Each panel plots the coefficient and 90% confidence interval on the Black-and-Hispanic $\times$ Republican-identifier interaction in a model of the form $y = \alpha + \beta \cdot \text{treat} + \gamma \cdot \text{Rep} + \delta \cdot (\text{treat} \times \text{Rep}) + \mathbf{X}'\boldsymbol{\theta} + \varepsilon$, reported separately for each of the six policy outcomes and under six nested specifications S0–S5. Specification S4 is the canonical specification used in Appendix Table A1. Party3 is omitted from S5 to avoid collinearity with the Republican indicator. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors.

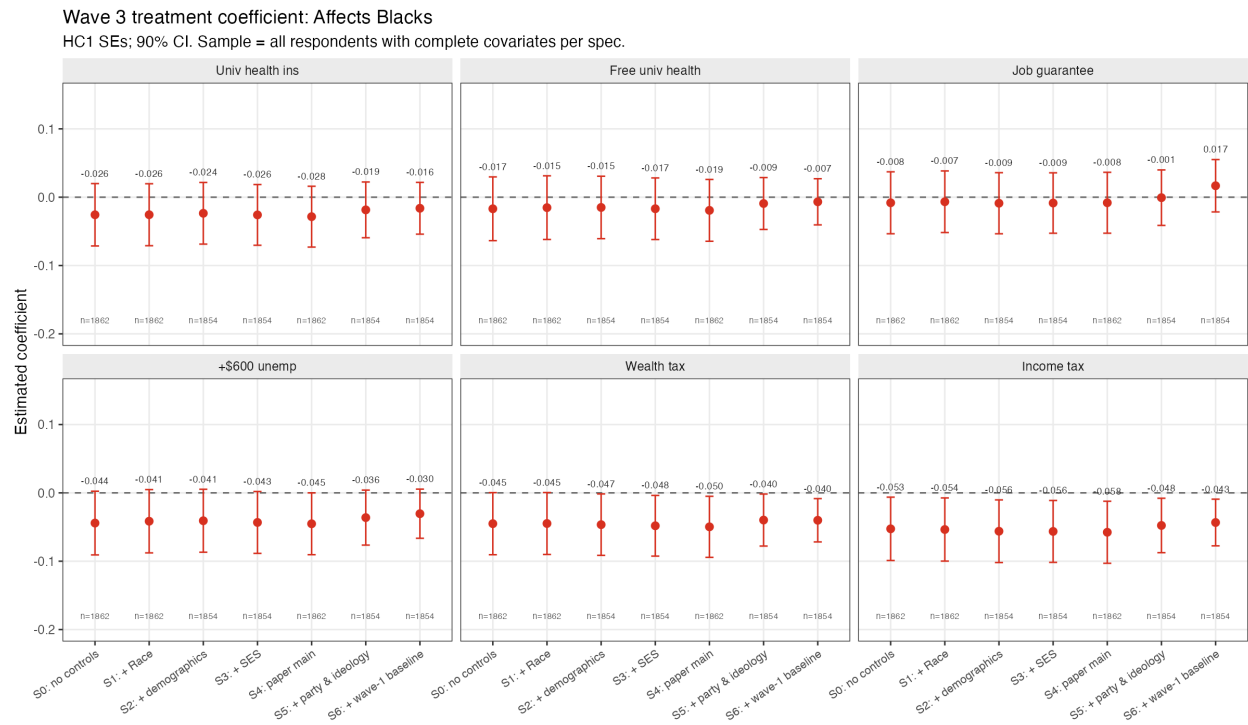


Figure OA.12: Wave 3 “affects-Blacks” (T1) treatment coefficient across specifications

Note: Each panel plots the estimated coefficient on the “affects-Blacks” treatment indicator (and 90% confidence interval) for one of the six policy outcomes, under seven nested specifications S0–S6. Specification S4 is the canonical Wave-3 specification used in Appendix Table A1. Specification S6 additionally controls for the respondent’s Wave-1 response to the same policy item. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. Sample sizes reflect complete-case covariate coverage for each specification.

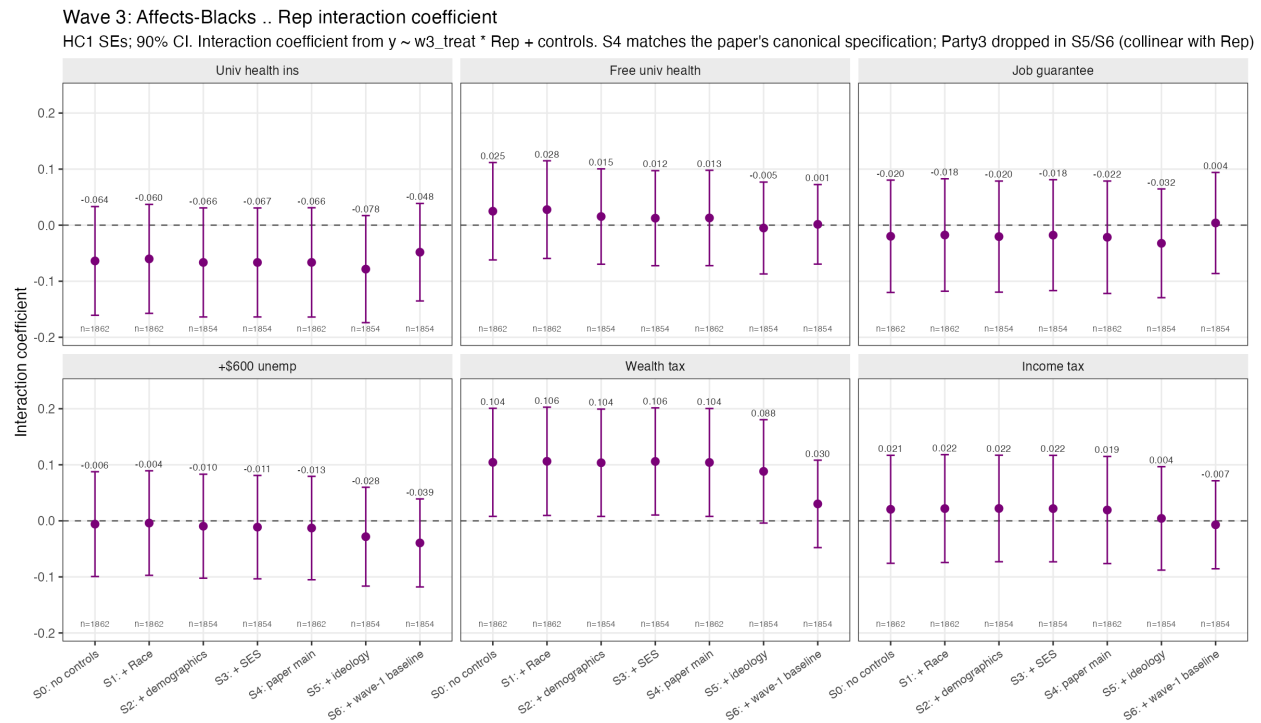


Figure OA.13: Wave 3 “affects-Blacks” $\times$ Rep interaction coefficient across specifications

Note: Each panel plots the coefficient and 90% confidence interval on the “affects-Blacks” $\times$ Republican-identifier interaction in a model of the form $y = \alpha + \beta \cdot \text{treat} + \gamma \cdot \text{Rep} + \delta \cdot (\text{treat} \times \text{Rep}) + X'\theta + \varepsilon$, reported separately for each of the six policy outcomes and under seven nested specifications S0–S6. Specification S4 is the canonical Wave-3 specification used in Appendix Table A1. Party3 is omitted from S5 and S6 to avoid collinearity with the Republican indicator. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors.

OA.3 Proofs

This appendix provides the algebra for the cue-effect formula stated in Eq. (3) and the sign analysis used in the main text. Equation references cross-refer to the theory subsection: Eq. (1) for voter utility, Eq. (2) for the perception update, and Eq. (3) for the cue's effect on utility. Assumptions (A1) and (A2) are the substantive restrictions on the parties' positions stated in the main text and used here without restatement.

1. **Primitives.** Voter j has personal ideal point x_j and partisan identity $P_j \in \{R, D, \emptyset\}$. Their party (when one exists) has a baseline perceived position $\bar{x}_{P_j}^N$ and a race-targeted anchor $\bar{x}_{P_j}^T$. Under the cue ($\rho = 1$), the perceived party position shifts according to Eq. (2); the voter's utility from policy p is given by Eq. (1). We treat voters with no party affiliation as having $\alpha = 0$, in which case the cue does not enter their utility and $\Delta U_j^{(t)} = 0$ trivially.

2. **Effect on perceived party position.** Differencing Eq. (2),

$$\bar{x}_{P_j}(1) - \bar{x}_{P_j}(0) = \theta_t (\bar{x}_{P_j}^T - \bar{x}_{P_j}^N) = \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{P_j},$$

where $\Delta \bar{x}_{P_j} \equiv \bar{x}_{P_j}^T - \bar{x}_{P_j}^N$ is the partisan position gap.

3. **Effect on utility.** The personal-utility component $-(1-\alpha)(x_j - p)^2$ does not depend on ρ and cancels when one differences $U_j(p, 1) - U_j(p, 0)$. The cue's effect therefore operates entirely through the partisan-utility component:

$$\Delta U_j^{(t)} \equiv U_j(p, 1) - U_j(p, 0) = -\alpha \left[(\bar{x}_{P_j}(1) - p)^2 - (\bar{x}_{P_j}(0) - p)^2 \right].$$

Substituting $\bar{x}_{P_j}(0) = \bar{x}_{P_j}^N$ and $\bar{x}_{P_j}(1) = \bar{x}_{P_j}^N + \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{P_j}$ and expanding the first squared term,

$$(\bar{x}_{P_j}^N + \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{P_j} - p)^2 = (\bar{x}_{P_j}^N - p)^2 + 2 \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{P_j} (\bar{x}_{P_j}^N - p) + \theta_t^2 \Delta \bar{x}_{P_j}^2.$$

Subtracting $(\bar{x}_{p_j}^N - p)^2$ and collecting,

$$\begin{aligned}\Delta U_j^{(t)} &= -\alpha \left[2 \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{p_j} (\bar{x}_{p_j}^N - p) + \theta_t^2 \Delta \bar{x}_{p_j}^2 \right] \\ &= -\alpha \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{p_j} \left[2 (\bar{x}_{p_j}^N - p) + \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_{p_j} \right],\end{aligned}$$

which is Eq. (3).

4. **Sign analysis: Republicans.** Under (A1), $\bar{x}_R^N - p \geq 0$ and $\Delta \bar{x}_R > 0$. The bracket

$$2 (\bar{x}_R^N - p) + \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_R$$

is therefore non-negative, and is strictly positive whenever $\bar{x}_R^N > p$ or $\theta_t > 0$. The factor $\theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_R$ outside the bracket is non-negative (≥ 0 , strict when $\theta_t > 0$). Multiplied by $-\alpha \leq 0$,

$$\Delta U_j^{(t)} \leq 0,$$

with equality only when $\alpha = 0$ or $\theta_t = 0$. The cue weakly reduces Republican support for the policy.

5. **Sign analysis: Democrats.** Under (A2), $\Delta \bar{x}_D \approx 0$. The factor $\theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_D$ outside the bracket is approximately zero, so

$$\Delta U_j^{(t)} \approx 0$$

for Democratic identifiers regardless of θ_t .

6. **Comparative statics.** For Republican identifiers, taking the derivative of $|\Delta U_j^{(t)}|$ with respect

to θ_t , holding the other primitives fixed,

$$\frac{\partial |\Delta U_j^{(t)}|}{\partial \theta_t} = \alpha \Delta \bar{x}_R \left[2 (\bar{x}_R^N - p) + 2 \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_R \right] \geq 0,$$

strictly so whenever $\alpha > 0$, $\Delta \bar{x}_R > 0$, and $(\bar{x}_R^N - p) + \theta_t \Delta \bar{x}_R > 0$. Analogous calculations give

$$\frac{\partial |\Delta U_j^{(t)}|}{\partial \alpha} \geq 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial |\Delta U_j^{(t)}|}{\partial \Delta \bar{x}_R} \geq 0,$$

each strict under analogous non-degeneracy conditions. The magnitude of the cue's effect on a Republican identifier is therefore increasing in θ_t , in α , and in $\Delta \bar{x}_R$.